But there is often a tendency in these ballad-mongers to mix up folk-stories with historical facts. The present ballad suffers from this drawback. The earlier portion seems to be pure folk-lore. We have heard times without number the stories of princes put in sub-terranean regions by the freaks of astrologers' calculations and of monarchs who would not see a child's face lest some great mishap should befall them, as predicted by wise men. But while discarding this portion of the ballad as incredible, the latter portion narrating the love of the princess "Adhuya Sundari" for Jamal Khan, and other subsequent developments of the story, cannot be dismissed by us as a mere fiction. These form the pivot round which the whole story, mixed up with fiction and rustic fancy moves. It had, no doubt, its origin in historical facts. It is true, that ignorance, superstition and want of culture have led to a distortion of the narratives in various ways, but still through the vista of popular narration, glimpses of social condition and torn pages of lost history may be revealed by future research. It will help, let us hope, in threshing out the grain from the chaff in future.

The Muhammadans often took fancy for Hindu maidens, and many disastrous wars were fought "for amorous causes" of this nature, as will be seen from many of the other ballads collected by Babu Chandra Kumar from neighbouring localities.

I have stated the reason in my Introductory notes to one of these ballads published in Vol. I, and I take the liberty to refer to it again. Most of these Muhammadan Dewans and chiefs belonged to families converted from Hinduism to Islam. They were guided by Hindu tastes and preserved naturally a predilection for the Hindu society, which, however,

regarded them as 'untouchables.' This contemptuous treatment of a people, who held the power, often gave rise to a sense of wrong, for which retaliation was sought for by application of force. The Baniachang Dewans were Brahmins before their conversion. The treatment the old minister received from Raja Dubaraj, as described in the ballad, would naturally create a fiery animosity between any two unconcerned peoples. But here both the families were originally of the same stock; hence the sting of insult was felt all the more. Jamal Khan seems almost justified in our eyes in leading an expedition to carry the maiden Adhuyā by force.

Such causes would probably have never arisen if genuine Muhammadan families, recruited from Persia or other western homes of Muhammadans, had settled in the country and lived as neighbours of the Hindus. They would not have cared to covet Hindu wives in the way described in the ballad. True, in the history of Rajputana the contrary facts are sometimes observed. But that is because the Emperors of Delhi wanted to subjugate the proud Hindus of martial races, and took recourse to all manner of oppression with that primary object in view. In peaceful state of political atmosphere such aggressions did not generally take place. The history of Mymensingh and Sylhet literally bristles with such instances. The reason seems to be that both the parties involved in such dissensions had the same blood running in their veins and were besides governed by almost the same tastes and ideas. It was for this that the Hindu girls had a particular charm in the eyes of their Muhammadan cousins, who though vested with power and political superiority, were treated with contumely by the Hindu community from a social point of view.

The language of the ballad is a mixed one. But though the number of Persian, rather Urdu, words is greater in it than in most of the other ballads written by Hindus, still it is very far short of what we find in the "Musalmani Bangla" in which the Battala presses of Calcutta publish the Islamic folk-lore and other poems. The Urdu element in the present case is not atrocious, but just what we find mixed in the dialect spoken by the Muhammadans in the country-side. There is very rarely any word over which the Hindu readers would halt. It is but fair that the Urdu words that have crept into our spoken dialect, understood by the Hindus and Muhammadans alike, should be given a currency in writing in order to make our language a common vehicle for literary purposes of the two sections of our community. But our Sanskritists scrupulously avoid Urdu words in writing, though in their colloquial dialect they cannot avoid using them. Such, for instance, are the words সল্লা (wicked advice), বকসিস্ (reward), লাখেরাজ (rentfree), গোলাম (slave), আপশোষ্ (regret), বাঁদী (female-slave) সয়তান (Satan, wicked man), দুষমন (enemy), বদ্ (bad), মুস্কিল (danger), ওস্তাদ (teacher), দুনিয়া (world), আস্‌মান (sky), জমি (land), আখের (end), দরিয়া (river), আছান (cure), বেইজ্জত (insult), হাওলি (apartment), বেইমান (ungrateful). These and a number of similar words are to be found in the ballad, most of which we use in our colloquial dialect, though we try to avoid them in our literary writings, in our enthusiasm to use Sanskritic words. I have dwelt on this point in my Introductory notes to Vol. I, at some length.

It is to be noted that the blind poet, as also the absolutely illiterate ones, generally give us words exactly as they are spoken in the country. This certainly deserves the attention of the philologists. The blind and

the illiterate never see words as they are written with their eyes, but always hear them with their ears. It is for this reason that our blind poet has so wonderfully reproduced the phonetic sound of the words, and the rhapsodists without any knowledge of letters have so truly handed us down the poet's version. Most of the writers, who have any knowledge of alphabets, would conform to their conventional use in writing. But the blind man here dictated his poem to the illiterate singers, true to the sound, without caring for literary or grammatical convention, as they were unaware of any. Thus in this ballad we find ছোড়ু for ছোট, পর্‌জা for প্রজা, চাঁন্ for চাঁদ, অইবে for হইবে, ছোন for শোন, ছাহা for সাহা, ছোক্ for শোক, বৈছান for বসানো, ছভা for সভা, পুন্নু for পূর্ণ, মাড়ি for মাটী, ছাহেব for সাহেব, ছফর for সফর, কাঞ্চা for কাঁচা, বচ্ছর for বৎসর, ছাথে for সাথে, ছমাচার for সমাচার, দুক্কু for দুঃখ, বির্দ্ধ for বৃদ্ধ, হাঁচা for সাঁচা, ছিড়াইল for ছিটাইল, সুরুয for সূর্য্য, তিরভুবন for ত্রিভূবন, শর্য্যায় for শয্যায়, পাত্থর for পাথর, লিয়া for লইয়া, অইব for হইব, রাজত্তি for রাজত্ব, পরনাম for প্রণাম, স্ত্রিরী for স্ত্রী, যৈবতী for যুবতী, and আনল for অনল।

It will be seen from the above list that the স of the Bengali alphabets still retains the sound of ছ amongst the peasantry, especially the Muhamamdans. Though amongst the gentle classes of Bengal the distinction in the pronouciation of শ, ষ and স has been practically lost and totally ignored. Another curious point to note is that what apperantly strikes us as an anomaly in rhyming in regard to certainwords used in the ballad, is not really so. For instanceছোক (শোক) and কুল (কোল) are given in the text as rhyming with মুখ and বোল. The actual pronunciation of the words in the district of Sylhet and Mymensingh are not শোক and বোল but শুক and বুল. So there is nothing that jars in our ears in the rhyme which retains its harmony when the poem is recited by the people of

those districts. In one place বাপ is made to rhyme with তাক্. This also is perfectly rhythmical, the abrupt ending of ক্ and প্ gives almost an identical sound to the two letters.

There are curious instances of verbal inflexions in the songs which will show a striking affinity with প্রাকৃত forms. Such as আইয়াম = আসিলাম, দেউখাইন = দেখুন as also দিউন, বইছান = বসান, ছাইড়িয়া = ছাড়িয়া, আছুইন = আছেন.

Compared with most of the other ballads collected by Babu Chandra Kumar, this one lacks in poetry. Though there is no lack of animation and interest in the story described, there is hardly any passage showing striking artistic beauty or poetical excellence. The poet in spite of his profuse use of colloquial words sometimes assumes an air of rustic pedantry specially when describing beautiful women. And in this his failure is of course obvious as he has no command over the artistic language of the classical poets, while the crudeness of patois often makes his style verge on the ridiculous. We do not find in this poem the simple rural charm and the direct epigrammatic style, so much in evidence in Mahua, Malua Chandravati and other poems. Shek Faizu's descriptions are often diffuse and monotonous, requiring a pruning here and there. Besides Fakir Faizu shows a strange lack of consistency by making contrary statements in various places of his poem. In one place he says that it took a man seven days to travel from Baniachang to Dakshinbhag, in another place he makes it five days and in the last canto the Dewan orders that the Raja of Dakshinbhag should be produced before him in less than 12 hours. The march of the army from Baniachang to Dakshinbhag and their return to the former city were to be covered by this "less than 12 hours!" In one passage Mecca is described as requiring six months to reach

from Baniachang and in another Delhi is mentioned as of equal distance from that city. These discrepancies might have been made by the singers, for, it is hard to believe that the poet who could give such a sustained interest to his story, was guilty of such obvious mistakes.

The earlier portion of the story, as I have already said, is pure folk-lore affixed to a historical ballad.[1] But even in folk-lore, the writer must subject himself to some limitations. The architect Tera-lengra in one passage travels to Hailaban in a day, though in a previous passage it was stated that it would take one six months to do so. Such gibberish is intolerable even in folk-lore. One thing however, should be always borne in mind that these ballads were composed, and sung, by men without any knowledge of letters. These anomalies are therefore not altogether unexpected.

Another fault that strikes us is the author's repetition of the same idea in different places. When a mishap takes place, the whole country becomes merged in sorrow; the men and women of the city cry and weep; the birds lament by their chirps, and horses and elephants shed tears in the stables. When Alal Khan, the old Dewan starts for Mecca, this happens first; the same thing is repeated when young Jamal is sent to Delhi. We find again a similar account when Alál leaves the city for good at the end of the tale: This song, I beg to repeat,

[1] We find similar accounts in some folk stories, this makes us surmise that the first portion of the story was a folk-lore; but instances of inhuman cruelties committed on children and women due to astrological predictions, are not quite rare. Pratapaditya was ordered to be murdered when he was a mere baby, for such a cause and owed his life to the intervention of his uncle Basanta Ray. The throwing of little children into Sagar was a practice which continued till quite recent times. The folk-story itself might have been based on some historical facts and such facts might not have been probably out of date during the time of the narrative. Events slightly similar might have been adopted from some folk-tale and dovetailed to a really historical account.

lacks in artistic and literary beauties which characterise the songs collected from Mymensingh. It has, however, historical interest and discloses certain social conditions an during Muhammadan reign which are interesting. The life in prison is graphically described. The cruel punishments mentioned are no exaggerations. The wrath of the chiefs, who on flimsy grounds ordered wholesale murder and made towns and villages desolate, show how helpless the country sometimes was at the hands of its autocrats. The people seemed to have no hand in administration and they suffered the utmost from such oppressions. But occasionally they asserted themselves by revolting against the tyrants. I have referred to this point in my Introduction to Vol. I. Chandra Kumar in a short note addressed to me, accuses Fakir Faizu of fabricating a story of a Hindu girl of aristocratic Brahmin family falling in love with a Mahomedan youth. But Sheik Faizu, it must be said to his credit, was never actuated by any ill-feeling towards the Hindus. He represents his views justly without any advocacy or partiality for his Moslem brethren. The indignation of the Raja at the offer of a proposal of marriage for his daughter by Jamal Khan has been described from the Hindu standpoint, and the letter Jamal Khan wrote to Adhuya was couched in a courteous language showing no aggressive or atrocious spirit which Moslem orthodoxy would suggest. In the prologue his benediction falls on the Hindus and Muhammadans alike in a truly cosmopolitan spirit, and if he described the love of a Hindu girl for a Muhammadan, it was perfectly in conformity with the inevitable law laid down by that blind god, who does not recognise any Hindu or Muhammadan in his jurisdiction, but inspires all who come in his way.

One word more and I have done with this preface. Throughout the poetical literature stamped with the spirit of the Pre-Renaissance school, we often come across the name Tera-lengra. In Mainamati songs, in the Dharmamangal poems and even in some works written in honour of Manasha Devi we come across this name every now and then. It seems to imply the nomenclature of a special class of servants privileged to go to the inner apartments of a palace. Tera literally means a man with a crooked glance due to some natural deformity in the eye, and Lengra means a lame man. We have heard of eunuchs, as chartered servants in the zenanas of the Moslem chiefs. It seems the Hindus were averse to the cruelty of maiming persons in that way. In the place of eunuchs they employed men who were naturally deformed and maimed and therefore safe and trusted parties to act as message-bearers in the Zenana.

The Tera-lengra in this ballad is an architect who had an access to the inner apartments for doing works of building and repair.

Surat Jāmāl and Adhuā.

A Love-tale and Tragedy

BY

FAIZU FAKIR.

Prologue.

First of all I bow to Allah—The Unknowable One. And then I bow to my Guru, who has given me a taste for spiritual life.

Tell me, oh my Guru ! where was I, when the sky was not, the earth was not and the sun and the moon were not.

Tell me, oh my Guru ! how could grain enter the husk and oil into the mustard seed and how could life enter the egg and where is the door by which death enters it ?

In the universe I have no other friend than Allah. He is my only friend and I have none other.

When my Hindu brother dies, they carry him to the river-ghat, and when a Muhammadan dies they bury him.

The sky is black, the land is black and deep black roll the waves of the river. But he who does an evil deed in return for good is even more black than they.

Says Fakir Faizu, "Oh my Allah ! I am humble and poor. From my birth thou hast deprived me of my eyes. No friend have I, no parents and not a brother ! May my soul find rest at thy feet in the end."

ADHUĀ.

The Begum sent to a sub-terranean house.

At Baniachang there lived two brothers. Here am I to-day to relate their story. I charge my audience to listen to me with forbearance and patience. Of the two brothers the elder was Dewan Alal Khan and the younger one was called Dulal Khan.

Both the brothers ruled the State together as Dewans. The elder brother was reputed for his high character, magnanimity of soul and many noble qualities. His subjects were pleased with his administration. In fact, for soundness of his judgment, they considered him as a second Rustum. His charity was as unbounded as that of Hatem. Language fails to describe adequately the great virtues of that noble man.

The wife of Dewan Alal Khan was Fatema Bibi whose beauty far exceeded that of any fairy or nymph of heaven.

One night she dreamt that the full moon had entered her womb. She awoke with a start and related this to her husband. The Dewan said that the meaning of the dream was that a beautiful son would soon be born unto her. In due course she conceived and was about to give birth to a child. The astrologer calculated the position of planets and said that it would be a male child, worthy of his illustrious father in every respect. He however stopped here and said with sorrow again, "I am afraid to tell the truth, but I cannot help doing so. If within twenty years of the birth of the child, you happen to see his face you will meet with a great mishap. Not only this but if within this period any man or woman living in your city, happens to see the face of this boy, he will be doomed to premature death."

When Dewan Alal Khan heard what the astrologer said, he sat down on the ground, stupefied by grief. He asked his dear brother Dulal Khan to convene a meeting of his chief officers.

The ministers, Nazirs and the police prefects all assembled together and began to discuss the matter at the Dewan's bidding. They at last arrived at a certain decision and the chief architect Tera-lengra was sent for. This man had elephantiasis in both his legs, which looked as heavy as the trunks of a banana-plant. His grand-sons, nephews, sons-in-law and other kinsmen numbered twelve thousand. He was a great architect, far superior to any that lived in the kingdom. This man, with his train of kinsmen and followers, occupied a large part of the city of Baniachang and daily consumed 12 maunds of *Ganja* drug. The great smoke spread all over the city and fully clouded the sky.

Dewan Alal Khan said to the architect, " You Lengra, you must be prepared to carry out my orders immediately. By the grace of God, you stand unrivalled in your profession. A child will be born to my wife in a week hence, as the astrologer has foretold, and one day is about to pass. To-morrow early in the norning you are to proceed towards the forest known as the Haliaban.

" There build a subterranean palace for me. It should be made of stone. You are to finish it at once. You will have ample rewards from me, and I will see that you are pleased with them." When the day dawned Lengra with his host of grandsons and kinsmen hurried towards the forest known as the Haliaban. In usual course it would require a man six months to cross that wild region so large a tract it was. Lengra with his people hurried on ; he had with him twelve thousand *Kodalias* (men who worked with spades). They levelled the ground

with their spades and the architect laid the foundation of the house with stone. Stair-cases were also made of stone. After having built the house Lengra returned home. He got 22 *puras* of rent-free land as reward for his labour, and for the rest of his life hoped to live happily with his sons, grandsons and kinsmen on the income of this extensive land.

The Dewan, in the meantime, sent his wife with one single nurse to live in this newly built sub-terranean house. Food, raiment and other articles for daily use were stored there that would last for twenty years.

(Ll. 1-72.)

(2)

The Dewan turns a Fakir.

With his ministers and other officers the Dewan, as usual, held the helm of his State. But his mind lost all peace after having sent his Begum away. His city and palace looked void and he wept at whatever he saw around.

One day Alal addressed his younger brother and said, "No longer, brother, do I like to be the Dewan of this region. My city, my realm, my palace, and all I will give up, and go away to a remote shrine. What good, dear brother, will the possession of all these bring unto me? When I shall die, not a *cowri* will go with me. In the dead silence of the burial ground will this body of mine rot and worms will eat my flesh. Sons, daughters and friends all flock round one who is able to bear their burden, but they will not be your companions in that solitary walk of life which every one must travel alone. I will henceforward take refuge in Him. I will turn a Fakir to sing His holy name. I am going to pay a visit to Mecca, where traces of the divine foot-prints still lie in the dust. I charge you,

my brother, to rule this land as Dewan during my absence for twenty years. If I ontlive this period, I will return home.

So did the Dewan take the Fakir's staff in his hands, put on a turban and dedicated himself to Allah. He went alone leaving his palace; and all the people mourned for him in bitter grief. The ministers and officers, his relations and friends silently wept. Even the dumb animals of the stall—the elephants and horses—shed tears as he left the palace. The ministers and others gathered round him on the eve of his departure and asked him to allow them to accompany him. "We are your loyal servants," they said. "Do not leave us, we pray." But Alal Khan said, "I am resolved to go alone without taking even a *cowri* from the State." Thus did the Dewan start for Mecca all alone like a beggar. (Ll. 1-32.)

(3)

The Prince discovered by his Uncle.

Now let me revert to the topic of the poor Begum who, with a single nurse, lived in the jungly lands of Hamila. On the expiry of ten months and ten days from her conception she gave birth to a son. She, who had been accustomed to sleep on a golden couch, now lay on a mat spread on the floor of that dismal subterranean house. She had countless female attendants in the palace, but here one single maid-servant ministered to her comforts, serving food, when hungry, and offering water, when a-thirst. On the expiry of six days of her coming to that place which she had spent in sorrow and hope, a son was born unto her, bright as the full moon. She became so happy on getting the child on her

lap that she forgot the loss of the palace, of her attendants and a hundred other comforts. She shed tears saying, "If the Dewan would have heard the news of his son's birth, he would have emptied his whole treasury, spending all on charity. But now this poor gem of mine shines in this dark cave here, having none to look at it. Ah me! how miserable am I!" A bright necklace of pure diamonds hung on her breast. She took it off and made a gift of it to her maid-servant, saying, "Oh my solitary attendant, I hold you dear as a parent—or a sister. In the sea of unfathomable grief into which I have fallen, you are my sole refuge and guide."

One—two—three months passed. The child grew like the waxing moon. By the grace of God, one year passed. The child crawled in the court-yard and sometime lisped the word "mother" in half-broken syllables. To her he was dear as a rib of her heart. She gave him the name of Surat-jāmāl.

Now one day Dulal, the younger brother who ruled the kingdom as Dewan Saheb in the place of his elder brother in Baniachang, went to that forest for hunting purposes with a large number of followers. It looked like a regular sea of human heads flooding the land as they entered the forest Hailaban. The Dewan saw wood-cutters hewing wood, helped by their young children. When these young urchins helped their elders in cutting wood, Dulal Khan stopped a moment and was astonished to find amongst the dusky sons of wood-cutters, a bright boy shining like the full moon. "Whose son may he be, beautiful as a cherub?"—he thought within himself and as he looked closely the resemblance that the child bore to Alal, his father, became apparent, and the junior Dewan began to think, "Such a handsome boy in this

forest amongst the dusky wood-cutters,—he cannot be any other! No doubt he is Fatema's son—bright as the moon. He seems to be a lad of seven years. I never saw a lad as handsome as he." And he calculated the period and found that Fatema had been sent to the forest seven years ago.

"Now after seven years I meet him for the first time. The astrologer had predicted that should any of us see him before he attained his twentieth year, there would be a dire disaster.

"I do not know, Oh Allah, if the astrologer was right. But what is to befall me is inevitable now. Let me think no more"—he thought in this strain and returned to his city with his followers. (Ll. 1-54.)

The Conspiracy.

Now Dewan Dulal came back to his palace and summoned all his courtiers. The old minister hastened to meet the Dewan; the Karkun, the Munshi, the Nazir and other officials assembled in the palace. The Dewan told them what he had beheld in the forest. All of them put their heads together and devised plans as to how the little child, the son of Alal, should be killed. They said, "You are now the master of the country—our popular Dewan Saheb. You are the legitimate owner of all that you have been long enjoying. Your brother became old and left the country in your charge. He is far off and there is no knowing if he still lives or is dead already. Rule this kingdom, oh revered lord, so long as you live and exterminate the enemy's brood." The Dewan said, "But how can I kill the child? Devise some well-matured plan if you would wish it."

The ministers, Nazir and others discussed the matter seriously and sent for Tera-lengra, the architect, who duly arrived at the town and paid his respects to the Dewan.

The Dewan said, "Hear me, oh old architect, I have fallen into a great trouble and hope to get over it by your help. I will make you a gift of the extensive Hāmila forest; cut down the jungle and live there happily with your children making suitable dwelling-houses. Now listen to what I want you to do. You remember that you built there the subterranean house for Fatema Bibi some years ago. You know where it is. You are to cover the same with earth in such a manner that the lady with her son may be buried alive."

When the old Prime-minister heard this order passed on the architect, he retired to solitude and rained tears in silence.

Forty *puras* of land, no joke! They are to be all rent-free. The reward is great. So Tera-lengra marched thither quickly with his men.

The old minister lost not a moment and applying whip to his horse hurried to the Hamila forest and arrived there in the shortest time.

He called Fatema Bibi aloud and when she presented herself to the trusted officer of the State, followed by her maid-servant, the Minister wept like a child as he delivered his message.

The Minister.

"Your happy days, dear lady, are over. Dulal Khan is now your enemy. He has resolved to kill you with your son. Tera-lengra, the architect, is coming here with 10,000 men. They will cover this house with earth and bury you alive."

When she heard the news, she helplessly wept and could not speak for some time. The young prince just returned there from the play-ground in the forest. He was hungry and demanded food from his mother. But as he looked up, he saw his mother weeping, resting her head on her hand. He asked the maid-servant, "What is the matter with my mother ? Why is she weeping and who is this stranger in our house ? "

The mother embraced her child and said weeping, "My heart breaks to tell you the story. I left my kingdom and have been living in this dismal place, but greater woes are awaiting me. Your uncle is now your enemy and our old minister has brought us very bad news."

The young prince saluted the old minister and then sorrowfully asked his mother as to what had happened. "I know no one whom to call my own "—said the prince turning to the minister, " I have been seeing my mother's tears ever since I can recollect the past. I asked her many a time, but she would not tell me where my home is. If I have my father living or I have any brother or relation,—would you, revered sir, unravel the mystery of my life to me. The minister related to him all that had happened in the past,—what the astrologer had predicted, how the subterranean house was made in the forest where his mother was removed, how his father unable to bear the grief of parting with his queen went to Mecca and how latterly his uncle resolved to kill him. " Oh young prince, your uncle is your sworn enemy. He has already sent Tera-lengra with orders to bury you and your mother alive." He added, " You are to leave this forest-home within the remaining hours of night. Don't tarry a moment."

Jamal Khan, the young prince, began to cry helplessly saying, " alas ! Alas ! We have no sympathiser, no

friend in this country. To whom shall we go ?" The mother and the son embraced each other and shed tears of despair. Jamal said, "Mother, where are we to go in this crisis ?"—and she answered helplessly, "Allah is our only refuge. None other do I see." They sought the old minister's advice and he said, after a moment's pause, "Your father, oh prince, had a great friend. He is the ruler of a western country. His name is Dubraj. Leave the forest to-night and proceed towards his dominions. Far off from this place is his capital and you will have to walk night and day. I myself will introduce you to the Raja." (Ll. 1-92.)

(5)

In the City of his Father's Friend.

They started at once and the faithful minister became their guide on the way. The prince prayed for the welfare of the young wood-cutters, his play-fellows, who held him dear as their life. The Begum was accustomed to journey in State-palanquins and Tanjams but now had, in this hour of great peril, to walk on foot. She went a few paces and then sat down to take rest ; and slowly did they travel in this way so that they could reach the capital of the Brahmin Raja on the seventh day.

It was mid-day and they had become quite exhausted with hunger and fatigue. The prince Jamal now with his mother and the minister reached the city of the Raja. The place looked so beautiful that it appeared to them as a land of fairies. At that hour the Raja was seated on a cushion in his private room. The young prince and the minister saluted him as a mark of respect as they approached him.

The Raja was struck by the handsome figure of the young boy and with a curious look enquired as to

whence he came and whose son he was. He ended with the query, "What it is that has brought you here, boy?" The old minister burst into tears unable to control his feelings, and then slowly wiping them away with his hand he thus introduced the prince to the Raja, "Alal Khan, Dewan of Baniachang was Your Highness' friend. This lad is his son. He has fallen into a great distress and come to you for help. Lady Fatema, his mother, is also here. She has accompanied us to this city. The boy's uncle has become his enemy. He sent his soldiers to murder him a few days ago."

When the Raja heard all, he embraced young Jamal with great affection and gave him a seat near his own on the cushion. He ordered rich meals for his guests; and his men sprinkled rose-water and *attar* on the prince's person.

A beautiful bungalow was raised in the outer apartments for Fatema Bibi and her son. The old minister also lived with them.

It became a custom with young Jamal to stroll in the southern part of the Raja's city every day for the sake of pleasure. A beautiful tank was there with landing *ghats* on its four sides, made of marble. Over each of these *ghats* gorgeous golden flags lay unfurled, and the young prince was pleased with the sight. He enjoyed all that he saw, and thus pleased with the city, he lived a happy life in his new home. One day, he softly spoke thus to his mother, "I shall tell you, oh good mother, of my resolve. I will go in the guise of a Fakir and visit Baniachang. I must see my father's kingdom with my eyes. Be kind, oh my good mother, to give me permission." The mother wept and said, "My cup of suffering has been full to the brim, I will not court new ones. I will not allow you to go to the

city of our enemies. I have no ambition. Rather I would beg alms from door to door and live on them."

Jamal Khan said a good deal but his arguments could not convince his mother. He could not secure the permission inspite of his eagerness and solicitude.

Now, shortly after this, the young prince came out of his house in the dead of night and with some of his picked friends and play-fellows proceeded towards the forest Haliaban. On reaching the place he found that all the trees there had been cut down. Lengra was now the master of the whole land. He had brought a host of low-caste labourers with him, who settled there. He had got 40 *purās* of rent-free land as his reward and he was living there with his people in prosperity. Arriving there, Jamal Khan saw the neighbouring localities all made desolate by the oppressions of Dewan Dulal Khan. The ryots were found bewailing their lot in great despair. Dulal Khan on some pretext or other, inprisoned their headmen. For arrears of rent he very often passed capital sentence, killing the men himself with his sword. They were often thrown into cages where the lions were kept or into prison-houses where chillies were burnt continually creating a burning smoke which choked their breath. Their beard was tied to posts so that they could not move their heads one way or the other. Wives and mothers of the ryots were brought to the Dewan's place and insulted. They often fled in numbers from their native country, leaving their house and property. (Ll. 1-74.)

(6)

Jamal Khan becomes the Dewan of Baniachang.

The prince returned and informed his mother of all that he had seen and heard. He was now sixteen years

old and resolved to acquire a training in the art of war. He joined the soldiers and began to practise with his shield and sword. In that kingdom of the Brahmin Raja he soon achieved fame for his cleverness in handling weapons. When he was twenty he sought the permission of his mother one day to go on a hunting excursion. "I am bound," he said, "for the Hamila forest for hunting purposes. I have got a large and well-equipped cavalry with numerous foot-soldiers, horses and elephants, from the Raja. Now do not, oh mother, stand in my way." Lady Fatema began to cry and she prayed to God that He might protect the lad from all dangers. He was the sole delight of her unfortunate life and was like the prop of a blind person—her only stay.

Now Jamal Khan, shortly after, started for the Hamila forest with his army. He attacked the whole host of Lengra, killed many of them ; and the rest of his people, about 10,000 men, took fright and fled away. The prince got Lengra arrested, and had him bound hand and foot with iron chains. Now, he marched to the city of Baniachang. The people of that large city looked with curiosity at them and wondered who might be the young hero who came with such a magnificent array of elephants and cavalry.

The prince applied whip to his noble steed, and through the dust raised by its hoofs the people caught a glimpse of him bright as the sun. But as soon as they heard that it was their own prince Jamal who had come, they joined his army in a body and laid siege to the palace. Dewan Dulal Khan, the enemy, fled by the back-door.

So the young hero took possession of his father's dominions and sent a message to the old minister at Dakshinbhāg. He, besides, sent the stately Tanjam of the palace to bring his mother back home. Lady

Fatema came in due course, and the Brahmin Raja Dubraj was right glad at what had taken place.

Jamal Khan, our new Dewan, began to rule the kingdom judiciously. Fakir Faizu says, "In all these affairs the Divine hand is to be traced. Jamal Khan had been but a beggar in the forest. But by His grace he now became a Dewan and see also how his uncle behaved! Oh my chorus, sing this Járee song keeping the time with your feet.[1] Now I will leave this topic and begin another. Many learned people have assembled to hear our song. Let me now sing the story of Adhuá. (Ll. 1-50.)

(7)

Adhua in Love.

Raja Dubraj had a daughter named Adhua Sundari. The fairies and nymphs of heaven were ashamed of themselves at the beauty of this princess. When she opened her large eyes and gazed at the sky, the sun hid itself behind the clouds in shame. She was the darling of her mother, and her five brothers held her in great affection. The couch whereon she slept was made of solid gold and she chewed betels of the colour of rose as she reclined on her couch for rest. Her five sisters-in-law with pretty hair-combs of mica bound her long hair into a chignon. One who beheld the glance of her large eyes, never cared to admire the dark clouds of the sky nor the dark waters of a river. She used to wear a *sadi* transparent and white like the waters of the Ganges. No fairy, no nymph would dare stand near her when she decked herself in her fine apparel. When she walked, her long hair almost kissed the ground and one who had but

[1] The singers dance as they sing.

once seen her would never be able to forget her in life. Youth had just dawned on her as she was barely sixteen. People said that in the whole *pargana* of Dakshinbhāg, there was not a second girl as beautiful as she.

Once Adhua went to the palace-garden to pluck flowers. She saw Jamal passing by the road bright as the moon. She admired his manly form, and thought that there was not another young man in the whole world so handsome. She stood and gazed at him. Each time she felt as if a thousand moon-beams shone from the place. One—two—three days passed in this way. All this time she did not leave her bed. The five sisters-in-law made enquiries: "Have you, dear one, fallen in love? Who may be the person who has captured your young heart?" The mother, father and the five brothers made kind enquiries and tried to soothe her mind by sweet words. But she uttered not a word and remained in bed day and night, weeping all alone. Her mother often remained with her in her room, but the love-sick daughter dreamt only of Jamal, while her mother made a hundred enquiries without knowing her mind. One morning she rose up and gathered the finest flowers from the garden. She wove them into a garland and then she wrote a short note and wiped away her tears again and again while reading it herself. She called one of her maid-servants into her room and told her, "A boon, oh dear Swapan (*lit.*—a dream, the name of the maid), I have to ask of you. Please go to the city of Baniachang with this garland and letter of mine. Give them to Jamal Khan and tell him how much I am suffering for him." Swapan departed and on the seventh day arrived at Baniachang. The prince was riding a carriage drawn by four horses. The maid interviewed him on the way.

She saluted him and gave him the garland with the letter. He asked her as to what it was that had made her travel all the distance from Dakshinbhāg and come to his city.

She said, "Your Highness, I am a stanger to you. In the country of Dakshinbhāg there lives the fair damsel Adhuā. No fairy is a match for her in point of beauty. She is indeed like a living flame at the dawn of youth. She is deeply in love with Your Highness and has sent me to you with these tokens. She has desired me to say that you lived there for eighteen years; you have got a kingdom now and forgot the country which gave you shelter at the time of your distress. Indeed, men are so forgetful and cruel. Adhuā requests you in her letter to pay a visit to Dakshinbhāg at least for a day and thus give her an opportunity of seeing you. This garland she wove with the choicest flowers that grow in the garden-city of Dakshinbhāg. Kindly accept this as her present and read the letter.

He read the letter and felt as if he was shot by an arrow. He dismissed the maid with a few words and said nothing to his mother nor to anybody else, but stepped into his own private chamber all alone. (Ll. 1-73.)

(8)

The Interview.

On the landing steps of the river lay the beautiful pinnace of the Dewan on anchor. In the morning the young Dewan ordered the boatman to be ready for a trip to Dubaraja's city. The wind was against the tide and carried the boat with all her sails unfurled in utmost speed, and Jamal Khan reached the landing *ghat* of the river facing Adhua's residence in three days.

The boat was moored there and the young Dewan seated on the roof appeared resplendent as the sun.

In the mornning Adhua with her maids went to the landing *ghat* for a bath. Her five sisters-in-law accompanied her. They talked and smiled gaily on their way. Their long and curling hair was scented with oil. They had each a golden pitcher in her hand. Some went in a playful gait, the weight of the fresh charms on their persons making their steps gracefully slow. Some had their hair bound into a knot, others with dishevelled hair, hanging down in curls. One had a beautiful garland of Champa flowers on her breast and another with eyes beautified by the black dye *kajjal* cast her quick glances around, and all had red powder of luck that brightened their forehead. A maiden wore a waist-belt from which the golden pendants made a merry sound. Some had silken robes and others clothes that shone with the colour of the sky. The damsels gaily dressed came to the bathing *ghat*. Amongst them there appeared Adhua as does the moon among her attendant stars.

Stricken with love she looked thinner, but still her beauty shone like a spark of fire. She cared not for her hair, which uncombed, had become knotted. Still her face looked fair as the moon. She stood on the landing *ghat* and saw the stately boat anchored there. On the roof sat Jamal who appeared like the sun peeping from the east at the dawn of the day. Flowers of various hue and size appeared in their full bloom from the banks of the river and over these hummed a hundred bees. From his boat Jamal looked at Adhua and was wonder-struck at her beauty, but he concealed his emotion and ordered the boatman to ply their oars and go homeward. On the eve of his departure they had however exchanged mutual glances full of love's

message. And the bee thus left the flower before it could have the pleasure of a mere touch.

When she returned home she could not suppress her emotion. It became apparent in her tears which she vainly strove to hide. The mother as usual made kind enquiries, but she gave no reply, and leaving her couch lay on the bare floor, brooding over some unknown grief. "You are the darling of the whole house, my daughter," said the sorrowful mother, "held in great affection by your brothers. What can be the reason of your sorrow? When your soft lips gently utter the word 'mother' I feel thrice blessed. Tell me what ails you. Has any fairy cast her spell on you or did you see any bad dream last night, my child? Do not let any unhappy thought weigh on your mind, but tell me freely what it is that causes you pain"?

Fakir Faizu says, "No mother, it is not on account of any fault of yours that your girl is grieving. She has loved,—love is a great pain." (L. 1-60.)

(9)

The Proposal.

What do you think the young Dewan did, returning home? He called his old minister to his presence and said, "Here is this letter; carry it personally to Raja Dubaraja. He has a beautiful daughter fair as a nymph of heaven. Go to the court of the Raja and hand over my letter to him. You will first orally communicate my message and tell him, "Hindus and Mahammadans are the children of the same God. Prince Jamal Khan offers to marry Adhua—Your Higness's daughter. I come with this message"—saying so, deliver the letter."

With the letter in hand, the minister marched towards Dakshinbhāg. He went with a large number of followers, some of whom rode elephants and others horses. He took with him a number of valuable jewels as dowry. It took him five days to reach the place. He presented himself at the Durbar of the Raja and having scented the letter with *attar* communicated the proposal verbally, and respectfully handed the letter over to him. (Ll. 1-18.)

(10)

Insult to the Minister.

The Raja was a Hindu and, besides, a Brahmin. As soon as he heard the proposal, he burst forth into a terrible fit of anger and became like burning fire. He ordered the public executioners to throw the old minister into a dark prison. He was kept there for a week with a heavy stone on his breast. A regular array of ants was let loose to plague him in bed.

All his beard was plucked by force and he was made to roll and whirl like a ball, being pushed from behind. One of his ears was cut and his body was scorched in several places by means of hot iron. After seven days, he was turned out of the city, being driven by the neck.

The minister in that sorry plight reached Baniachang and related the story of his insult to the Dewan with tears in his eyes. He concluded by saying, "It is for you, my lord, that I have lost one of my ears and been put to such grievous insult in the presence of all." (Ll. 1-16.)

(11)

Retaliation.

He became like fire, inflamed by wind at this report and ordered his army to be ready for war. The soldiers

all cried, "Allah, Allah" and made preparations for an expedition. The elephants and horses were gaudily caparisoned and the soldiers showed great enthusiasm armed with their spears, arrows, swords and shields. They looked terrible as death, as they marched on.

The dust raised by the hoofs of horses created clouds in the sky. All who claimed any connection with Nabi assembled on this errand and they raised the war-cry, "Allah, Allah" which, so to speak, rent the sky. The citizens wondered at the brilliance of the army, as they saw Jamal Khan marching at the head of them mounting a noble steed. (Ll. 1-12.)

(12)

The Two Brothers.

Let us refer to the topics of Dulal Khan, brother of Alal, whom Jamal had driven from his *gadi.* When his nephew took the reins of administration in his own hands driving Dulal from the country, the latter turned a Fakir and after travelling six months on foot reached the shrine of Mecca. He met his elder brother Alal in that sacred city and bowed to him with all humility. He actually cried when he thus gave an account of himself: "Hear, my esteemed brother, the tale of my woes caused by your wicked son. He has turned me out from our city and I am no better than a Fakir to-day as you see. The subjects have taken fright at his conduct. He does not spare the womankind in his sweeping oppression. There in his harem are to be seen old and young women of respectable families bound in iron-chains. There is no man whose honour is safe in his kingdom. You are away from the country and live in Mecca letting such a son to reign in your place!"

When the old Dewan heard all this he became so angry that he could not speak for some time. He accompanied his brother homeward and first came to Daskhinbhāg, the place where his friend Dubaraja reigned. The two friends met after a long time and they embraced each other in great affection. Alal Khan asked of him a report as to the conduct of his son. It should be remembered that Dubaraja had, now, become an enemy to Jamal Khan. He gave a false report, nearly confirming all that Dulal had said.

Now, Alal Khan with his friend the Raja, who led his vast army, went to lay siege to the city of Baniachang. It was a vast army looking like surging waves at a time when a storm breaks. They looked menacing and grand as they proceeded onwards with swords and shields,—with elephants and horses.

Like two great streams rushing forth from cliffs and infernal regions and meeting one another, the two armies met and stood facing each other in a menacing attitude. The army of Baniachang stood ready for fight and displayed a great enthusiasm. But when young Jamal came to know all, he laid his shield and sword on the ground. He left the army and humbly walked to meet his father. The father and the son met in the open field. The old man became incensed at the sight of his son and looked like dry leaves that had caught fire. He planned to give order for the immediate execution of the young hero. At his order, they bound Jamal hand and foot with hard iron-chains. His glory was eclipsed like that of the moon under the demoniac power of Rahu. Alal Khan, after this act, arrived at the city of Baniachang. For seven days Jamal Khan was kept in a dungeon with a heavy stone on his breast.

Helpless as he was, he cried for the mercy of God. After seven days, judgment was to be delivered on him.

Such are the mysterious ways of Providence. Let me describe the incidents that followed. (Ll. 1-52.)

(13)

The Contents of the Mysterious Letter.

One would take full six months to travel on foot from Baniachang to Delhi. The monarch of the great Empire resided in that great city. From there a letter came to the Dewan. But none could decipher its contents. Both the pages of the folio seemed blank, and the Dewan Alal Khan was at his wit's end to make any meaning out of the message conveyed by the royal communication. The ministers and other officers of the State each tried his best, but none could discover any alphabetical sign in the letter. Alas! who was the person that had played such a deception! The penalty for not complying with the royal order would be death. What should they now do at this crisis? The news spread in the city and there was none there who had not heard it. It became a gossip with the house-holders and soldiers alike. Prince Jamal heard of it from the prison. He became curious to see the letter and sent one of the jail-constables to his father asking him to show him the curious document. Alal Khan accompanied by his officers and friends himself went to the prison with the letter.

The letter was handed to Jamal in the dark cell in which he was, and a man was sent to bring a light there. Jamal Khan, in the meantime, had opened the letter in the dark and held it before his eyes. In darkness the letters of the epistle sparkled brilliantly and

Jamal at once read out its contents before his father. He said, "Oh my revered father, the great Emperor wants an army from you. He wants ten thousand soldiers and a good number of horses. His command is that within seven days the army should reach the city. Non-compliance with the orders will subject you and your children to a sentence of death."

Alal Khan was on the horns of a dilemma at this stage. "How can I go to the field within seven days?" he thought within himself. "But if I fail to carry out the order, the risk will be the loss of life, inflicted on myself and on the whole family." (Ll. 1-34.)

(14)

Jamal sent to War.

He asked the ministers and other officers to state their opinions as to who should be sent to Delhi. Just at that moment Raja Dubaraja thought, "If Jamal be not sentenced to death by the Dewan, there will be no retribution at all. So far as I can see, the father's affection may prevail and he may be discharged after a mockery of trial; this is the opportune moment to send him to the fatal war."

Thinking thus he said to Alal, "My dear friend, why do you worry yourself on this point? Send Jamal with an army. He is skilled in the art of war and I am sure he will come back a victor."

Alal approved of the suggestion and said to Jamal, "Now dost thou go, oh Jamal, and save our family and children."

He bowed to his father respectfully and became ready to go to Delhi at the head of an army to fight for the Emperor.

In the inner apartment the Begum Sahebā heard the news. She was afraid and called her son to her presence. He came fully equipped and dressed as a soldier for bidding her adieu. She said, "Alas, oh my son—" but could not complete the sentence. Then controlling herself she said, "Are you going to take leave of me? Oh, what words of consolation would you give to your poor mother at this hour of parting? You are the light of my eyes. How shall I live without seeing your face bright as the moon,—without hearing your words sweet as honey,—without hearing that affectionate address 'mother' from your lips? A mother alone knows the pangs of a mother's heart. How can others know that? If you go away whom shall I have left in this world to call as mine own? I know not whose garden full of ripe fruits I destroyed or whom I robbed of his wealth for which I have deserved this sentence from Providence. When I shall rise in the morning how shall I bear the long day without seeing your moon-like face but once?"

The lady lamented long in this strain. Jamal Khan said affectionately, "Bless me, oh mother, so that I may return victor from the field. Do not lament and cry at this hour."

The mother blessed the brave child, and taking leave of her, Jamal started for the great city of the empire.

(Ll. 1-50.)

(15)

Letter to Adhua.

Now listen, oh brethren, to what happened to Adhua. On the way Jamal ordered his army to halt and take rest

for a short time and at this interval he wrote a letter to Adhua which ran thus :—

" Do you, oh maiden, still recollect poor Jamal ? I am summoned to Delhi for joining the war that is raging there. Probably I go never to come back to my native land. You are, I am sure, unaware of this. Surely you will feel a gap in your heart for me. Is it not a pity that I am not allowed to meet my love and take the gift of sweet betels from her dear hands even once in my life ? I am now a Fakir and leave my home for ever. Adhua, my bitterest grief is that I shall not see your face bright as the moon and never again shall we meet in life. Great hopes had I that I would be happy in life, securing you for my bride. But that is never to be. I could not personally take a final leave of you. This grieves me most. But if, by the grace of God, I ever return to my country I shall do all in my power to get myself united with you in wedlock."

He closed the letter and wiped away his tears that had sprung from his eyes. He took off the diamond-ring from his finger and sent it along with the letter to Adhua.

With his ten thousand men, he next proceeded towards Delhi. He saw many bad signs on the way. On the left side, some one sneezed as he started. A fly blown by the wind sat on his eye-lid. His noble war-horse stumbled and got a hurt in the leg. He saw wood-men carrying loads on the way and as he turned back, he heard the cry three times, ' Stop, stop, stop.' At this point he saw a corpse being borne on the shoulders of men for cremation. It appeared to him that some one was lamenting in the air as he went on. All these omens were observed and he became pensive and sad, and weeping prayed to Allah to save him from all trouble and danger. (Ll. 1-38.)

(16)

The Tragical End.

One—two—three months passed, after which a letter came from the Emperor of Delhi. It contained the sad news of Jamal's death. All the old affection for the child returned to the Dewan at the report and he fell down on the bare floor struck by grief and looked like a banana plant blown down by a November storm. When restored to consciousness he began to cry and the Uzirs and other officers shared his great grief. The whole city of Baniachang mourned the loss of their beloved prince. Even the elephants and horses of the stall shed silent tears ; and the birds that lived in the forest or flew in the sky, stopped their gay notes for a time, stunned by grief. The flower-women lamented loudly. For whom, alas, would they weave garlands of flowers ? Loud lamentations were heard throughout the great city. And Faizu Fakir, the poet, says, " Don't grieve, oh citizens, but pray to God to restore peace to your mind."

When the dire news reached the inner apartments of the palace, Fatema Bibi fell senseless on the ground. The attending maids nursed her, but it was of no avail ; for, on the third day she expired.

Dewan Alal was lamenting over the Begum's dead body when the old minister came there and told him the whole history of his son's case. He said, " It is through your fault that you have brought ruin upon you." And then he related how, after the Dewan had gone to Mecca, Dulal Khan became an enemy of his son and sent ten thousand men headed by Lengrā with orders to bury Jamal Khan and the Begum alive. How they escaped death by the grace of God and how, like a beggar of the

street, Jamal went to Dakshinbhāg imploring the Raja's mercy with tears in his eyes; how he spent years in the city of Dubaraja; how he destroyed the town founded by Lengrā in the Hāmilā forest, and how he fought a hard battle and eventually he recovered his lost kingdom; how Dubaraja's daughter Adhua, a maiden fair whose beauty put to shame that of any fairy, got enamoured of him and herself first offered her love to the prince without his seeking it; how the old minister himself went to the court of the Raja with a proposal of marriage; how at his orders his police-staff arrested him and cut off one of his ears and insulted him in various ways, and how owing to this proposal the Raja got incensed at Jamal Khan, turned his enemy and advised the Dewan to send him to battle.

The old Dewan's wrath kindled like fire on hearing the story and his grief for his son's death increased tenfold. He called his generals and ordered them to bring the Raja to him, bound hand and foot, in the course of the night. His order was "fire is to be set on his city and the citizens are to be indiscriminately killed, their dead bodies rolling in blood are to be thrown into river; no house, no tree of that city is to spared; a regular river of blood should flow there, striking terror into the hearts of all."

The army naturally delighted in war and all martial operations went on in full speed, like fire while burning a forest. (Ll. 1-58.)

(17)

Poor Adhua

What did the princess Adhuā do when she received Jamal's letter? She hastened to the temple of Chandi and wiped it by her flowing hair. Her attending

maids made preparations for worship. Rice dried with the rays of the sun, clarified butter, bananas and sugar, sandal and vermilion and other articles were brought in plenty. She sat in a worshipful attitude before Chandi and prayed to her like a devotee. Just at that hour the army of the Dewan reached Dakshinbhāg. They seized the person of the Raja and dragged the princess out from the temple. In the morning they reached the city of Baniachang with the captives. In the way she heard loud lamentations near the city and learnt that Jamal had been killed in the battle. Under her thick curling hair she had hidden a small box of poison. She opened it now.....

They brought her out from inside the palanquin at the order of the Dewan. The Dewan said, "Kerumulla is the groom of my horses. Adhuā must be married to him. My grief will be assuaged by this insult." They dragged her out by her long hair but found her unconscious by the effect of the poison. Her long and curling hair lay there besmeared with dust. She looked like the full moon, come down from heaven to the earth. The Dewan's heart burst in grief at the sight of the beautiful princess and the memory of his lost son grew afresh in his mind. He saw a letter bound to the curling locks of the maiden. Alas! it was the one Jamal Khan had written on the eve of his departure. He also saw the diamond-ring of his son on a finger of the girl. "How could she get the ring of my son?"—he wondered. Then Alal brought his friend Dubaraja to his presence and related all that had happened. The two friends became once more united in common grief and cried embracing one another. Both had lost their children and both were stupefied by grief.

The old Dewan called his brother Dulal to him and said, "You wish to be the permanent Dewan; well and good; be what you wished; I shall again leave this place and turn the Fakir that I was. I shall never again come to Baniachang. The grief for my son is consuming me like fire."

He took leave of his minister and other officers and turned a Fakir, bound again for the holy city of Mecca. The ministers and other officers silently wept and the inhabitants of the whole kingdom were merged in grief at the renunciation of the Dewan; in the forest the birds lamented by their warbles; and the tears of the fish were merged in the river; the slaves struck their heads with their hands as a mark of sorrow; the people of the city sat stupefied with their heads bent downward and wept.

Dubaraja who was such an orthodox Brahmin, turned a Mahomedan convert, and started for Mecca.

The ministers and officers, as they saw the two friends start for Mecca as two Fakirs, were struck with vehement grief. "Alas, alas," they said, "behold the Dewan of an Empire goes away like a street-beggar!"

Faizu Fakir says, "What is the good of all these lamentations? Allah has written with his own hand the luck of each man—what he will do and what he will be—and this is unalterable. Take the name of Allah, my friends, for my story ends here. This world is vain; the name of Allah alone is true." (Ll. 1-64.)

THE END

FIROJ KHAN DEWAN.

PREFACE TO DEWAN FIROJ KHAN.

The name of the author of this ballad is not known, though there can be no doubt that he was a Muhammadan.

The name of Firoj Khan does not occur in the genealogical tree of the Dewans, so far as it has been available to us. As I find it to be the case in many of these ballads, I am convinced that the Muhammadan chiefs generally adopted dignified classical names on assuming the reins of administration.

Their more popular names, however, are to be found in the ballads. And there can be no question that this ballad, like some others about the Dewans of Jangalbari, embodies a good deal of historical facts.

Firoj Khan probably was one of Isha Khan's grandsons, he cannot be further removed from the great chief. As will be seen from the genealogical tree and the State-records of the Dewans, the property was afterwards divided amongst numerous scions of the family and the later Dewans, who were mere landlords of some status, could scarcely think of fighting with the Emperor of Delhi for independence.

Firoj Khan, as appears from the ballad, was a daring chief with his head full of notions of the glories of his ancestors. He was a lineal descendant of Isha Khan and occupied his *gadi* in full-fledged power and glory. We find it distinctly mentioned that "he was born in the family of Isha Khan." Such a reference would not be consistent, if he were a son of the illustrious founder of the family.

Isha Khan had two sons,—Musha Khan and Muhammad Khan. Musha Khan had a son named Machum Khan and Muhammad Khan's son was Eoaz Mahammad. For reasons already stated, we are reluctant to go down beyond the latter two names for finding out Firoj Khan in the genealogy of the Dewans. The genealogy of the Dewan-family supplied to us is neither exhaustive nor very accurate. We have elsewhere found the names of not only Abdul Khan as son of Isha Khan but of Adam and Biram, his two sons by his queen Sonamani—the Hindu princess of Sripur. Kellatajpur was a seat of another line of Dewans who probably came from the north-west and represented genuine Moslem blood. The vast field known as the Kellatajpur Maidan lies to the south of Netrakona, on the river Patkhora. Traces of the ditch and bricks of the old palace are still to be found in this tract of land.

Chandrakumar collected this ballad from three singers —(1) Sayabali Gayen of Fajilpur, (2) Sadir Gayen of Chandratala and (3) Rahaman Gayen of Katikhali. He got a portion of it from an old blind Fakir who begged alms from door to door and earned his living by singing. The above three singers were the pupils of the famous Ajib Gayen of Kabichandrapur in Pergana Nasir-u-jial. But the name of Jogir Gayen of Baraibari Jigatala in Pergana Susang, from whom Ajim had learnt the ballad is still famous in the country side as a singer of uncommon power. There

is another singer named Madan Byapari who sings another version of the ballad which is evidently distorted. He has introduced much of the old folk-element in it and described Sakhina as fighting with a club, 80 maunds in weight and performing other miracles like a Druid priest or a Tantrik Siddha.

The ballad keeps up a sustained interest, though it is not characterized by much poetry. The last scene redeems the prosaic narration of the preceding cantos and gives the whole song an almost epic grandeur. Sakhina's enthusiastic hopes of giving a reception to her lord on his return from the battle-field as a victor, are smothered by the cruel tidings which Daria communicates to her after some hesitation. But she bears the dire news of her husband being taken as a captive with the patience of a saint and her incessant fight in the field for 30 hours, dressed in man's attire, shows more than her martial skill and bravery—the supreme triumph of love. But a woman's heart, however strong, has a vulnerable point, and there she would scarcely be able to support herself even if the stroke be as soft as that of a flower. She who could fight like a lioness for a full day and night in the face of grim death roaring from the mouth of the enemy's cannon in the hope of rescuing her husband, and was looked upon by friends and foes alike to be indomitable in the field, dies of failure of heart, when the messenger comes running and shows her the letter of divorce by which her lord had brought on an amicable settlement with the enemy. She only pauses for a moment to look at the seal and signature of her husband to be too sure of it, and then drops down dead on the spot.

The ballad refers to facts which occurred in the latter part of the 19th century and must have

been originally composed not much later than that time.

The ballad of Firoj Khan is complete in 238 lines.

Firoj Khan Dewan.

(1)

First of all obeisance to Allah. Let us next narrate the history of Jangalbari.

The founder of the family was Kālidās Gajdāni who was so powerful that within his jurisdiction tigers and buffalloes drank from the same fountain without daring to quarrel with one another.

In his court Pirs, Fakirs and scholarly Brahmins daily assembled and discussed learned subjects. He made small figures of elephant plated with gold and distributed them amongst Brahmins. For this he was popularly called Gajdani or "giver of elephants." Heated were the discussions that took place in his court between the Muhammadan and Brahmin scholars. As a result of this continued discourses the Dewan's mind was purged of all evil thoughts, and gradually the right sense dawned on him; he gave up his infidel faith and turned a Muhammadan.

Kālidās Gajdāni had two sons,—of these two, I shall relate to you the story of Isha Khan. He revolted against the Emperor of Delhi who sent an army against him. Who was there so powerful as could cope with the royal army? Isha Khan was defeated at Douj Ghat. He crossed the Jayantia hills and fled. The army of the Emperor pursued him. They could not overtake him as he took refuge in the dense woods, and he then went upstream and landed at Jangalbari. In that city two brothers, Ram and Laksman, ruled at

that time. Isha Khan now went down stream and laid siege to their capital with his force. The two brothers fled from the city, which Isha Khan conquered. There the Dewan family became settled. And I will here relate to you the history of Jangalbari founded by Isha Khan. Great wrestlers came from different countries and bowed their head to Isha Khan with whom no one could cope in the strength of his arms. He measured forty *puras* of land there and built a new city on the plot. He had many large tanks dug in his city with landing *ghats* made of stone. In the bungalows with twelve gateways that he built, the doors were plated with gold. The windows, big and small sparkled in the sun as its rays were reflected on the glasses. Indeed the city with its smiling flower-gardens looked like a fairy land. The houses were equipped with crystal pillars, and gold was used in such profusion in the buildings that they shone with splendour from every corner. From the tops of the houses waved picturesque flags decorated with golden embroidery, and long staircases were all built with stone. The city shone as the moon, and the Dewan ruled the country from his magnificent palace.

Firoj Khan was a scion of this distinguished family. His fame had spread far and wide. One day his learned courtiers sat round him in his bungalow with twelve gate-ways. His ministers and high officers were there. And he addressed them thus: "At every stage of my life am I reminded of my glorious ancestors who had fought with the Delhi Emperors. The founder of the Dewan family, Isha Khan, was so powerful that even the Emperor of Delhi could not cope with him. I cannot forget for a moment that I am his descendant. Now hear me, my officers, what I have resolved to do. God Almighty has created me. It is He who has sent me to

Jangalbari. But I have so long kept my place as Dewan by sending half of the revenues that I gather from my subjects to Delhi every year. I do not care to retain my Dewanship on such a humiliating condition. Now listen to what I have been thinking of in my mind. I will henceforth cease sending revenue to Delhi. I will no longer attend the Durbar of the Emperor. Let the army of the Emperor do whatever they like. I will fight by the will of God and I am ready to court death if indeed that is the luck to which I am doomed. This is my resolve. I will myself call death to my doors."

Just as he had finished his address, a maid-servant came from the inner apartment. She said, "Your Highness' mother, the old queen, wishes you to see her immediately." The maid-servant after conveying this message saluted the Dewan and stood awaiting his reply.

The Dewan said to his officers, "My mother has sent for me, so let the Durbar close to-day ; I will settle everything to-morrow." (Ll. 1-88.)

(2)

Saying so, the Dewan entered the inner apartment and was instantly in the presence of his mother. The maid-servants offered the Dewan cool drinks of sweet *sharbat*. He drank and was refreshed and then reposed himself at his ease on a cushion. The maid-servants with fans decorated with mica fanned him and the mother gazed at his handsome person bright as the moon reclining on the couch, and she took pride in his manly features. The Dewan saluted his mother and said, "What is it, good mother, that made you send for me ?" She slowly said, "Do not be cruel, dear son, to your

old mama. As often as I see your face, I feel a pain in my heart which is not to be removed until you consent to marry. You are now in your full youth but you say that you will not marry. Will you not comply with my repeated requests? My days on earth are short, and I may soon go to my grave. My ardent wishes will be fulfilled if I can see the face of a beautiful daughter-in-law in this palace before my death."

The Dewan listened to the words of his mother with every mark of respect but said, "Can you feel, oh mother, what a pain I bear in my heart? The chief man of our family was Isha Khan with whom the troops of Delhi could not cope. The Emperor honoured him because he was a hero who could not be subdued even by his most valorous generals. In our illustrious family many a hero was born in the past. Now, hear my resolve. I will live an unmarried life. Day and night the thoughts of my State are uppermost in my mind. I have resolved not to send revenues to the Delhi Emperor any more. I will no more attend the Emperor's Durbar."

When the mother heard tha words of her son, she was struck with fear and sorrow and solicitously entreated him to change his mind.

Meantime, when the mother and son were engaged in serious talk, a picture-seller came there. A maid-servant offered her a seat in the room. She opened her chest full of pictures and the maids stood surrounding her, when the pictures were brought out one after another. The old queen asked her son to purchase a good one, offering to pay the price herself. The Dewan looked into the pictures and selected one. He was evidently struck with it and asked the woman, "What fairy of Bchest is so beautiful? Will you pray

tell me whose picture is this ? I have seen pictures of fairies whose colour is all crimson and those whose colour is beautiful blue, and in fact, the whole host of those who dwell in the fairy land, but I never saw a fairy like this ? Where does she live ? Who, alas, is her fortunate mate ? " The picture-seller smiled and said, " Listen to me, my young prince, she is not a fairy. She is the daughter of Omer Khan, Dewan of Kella-Tajpur. She is a grown-up girl but is not yet married. She will marry if she gets a groom after her choice."

Firoj Khan selected this picture and kept it. When the woman wanted the price, the old queen was so very pleased that she presented her with her own necklace. The picture-seller was right glad and took betels from the queen's hands along with the necklace and departed saluting her. (Ll. 1-76.)

(3)

Chorus.—" The river of love went upstream and with it his mind."

The Dewan kept the picture with his mother and went to his own room. He reclined upon his couch and thought within himself, " I never saw a woman of such exquisite beauty. There is none amongst the mortals to match this figure. It seems that God-Almighty sat in a lonely place and bestowed His whole thought in modelling her lovely form ; her limbs are fair and round as if worked out by the finest chisel. The colour has the glow of a ripe banana and at this dawn of youth her face looks like a water-lily. If one sees her but once, one's eyes are charmed. Yet it is but a likeness. I wonder how the figure itself would look ! My mind, it seems, is losing its balance, and

I cannot think of anything else. Who is the fortunate one for whom God has created this sweet creature ? "

Firoj Khan became thus absorbed in wild and romantic thoughts and cared not to attend his administrative duties. The ministers and other officers could not make out the reason of this change. The Dewan neither took his bath nor his meals in proper time. There was evidently something wrong in his head. Meantime the revenue due to Delhi fell into arrears. The minister called on him and acquainted him with this and other important affairs of the State. The Dewan said, " Hear me, oh my trusted officers, the position that I hold has no more any charm for me. I want to take leave for some time. You are to act in my place during my absence. Govern the country well and justly. I shall be absent for a little while and go on a hunting excursion."

The Dewan, shortly after this, saw his mother and asked leave of her. "I am going away," he said, "for hunting and shall be absent for a short while. The forest of Sonakandi is the abode of wild beasts. Large tigers and bears infest these woods and every year make a havoc amongst my subjects in the locality. The people there are in a constant state of alarm and many have deserted their homes in fear. The wild buffaloes of the place are no less ferocious and they also kill my men every now and then. My heart melts in compassion for my poor subjects, and I am determined to save them from their danger. I have come to you to ask your permission to set out with this object for Sonakandi." The mother wept and said, "How can I live, dear son, without you in this palace ? You are the candle of my house and the light of my eyes. The whole world will appear dark to me during your absence from home." Saying so, she wiped away her growing tears. She prepared meals with five curries with

her own hand and affectionately served him on the eve of his departure.

Firoj Khan started with his army.—The dust raised by the hoofs of horses covered the sky. The soldiers were maddened by enthusiasm in the prospect of a chase and the Dewan pitched his tents at a place near the down-stream of the river flowing in the locality. He halted at the forest-side for some days. But hunting was a mere pretext. He was planning to visit the city of Kella-Tajpur all the while and could not for a time settle what path he would follow to reach that city. He called his Foujder (general) one day and said to him, "Stay here for twenty-four hours. I will go away and will be absent for one full day and night." The Foujder saluted him and departed. Now the Dewan was thinking of nothing else excepting Sakhina—the daughter of the Tajpur Dewan. In the mid night he disguised himself as a Fakir with Daspanja(?) in his hands befitting a fakir; he proceeded on his way counting the sacred beads. He walked with a great speed, journeying in three hours what in normal state would take twelve hours to travel. Thus did he reach the city of Kella-Tajpur in the shortest time and take his seat under a tree, reciting the name of Allah like a true Fakir.

The people who had been going by the road were attracted by the appearance of the Fakir and sat surrounding him under the tree. Some of them wanted medicine for the diseases they suffered from; some stretched their hands before him believing that the Fakir knew something of palmistry. Some wanted him to examine their forehead and foretell what was written in their luck; others, who were childless, prayed for using his miraculous powers so that they might get children, and promised him *sinni* or religious gifts as reward. Others again abused him saying

that he was a rogue under the guise of a Fakir. Some took compassion on him and spoke affectionately regretting that in his early youth he had cut off all ties with the world and turned a Fakir. They wanted to know what was the trouble or disappointment that had made him so disgusted with the world that he abandoned it in early youth.

Omer Khan, the Dewan, ruled over that place with his ministers and officers. Sakhina was his daughter, whose beauty dazzled all eyes, and attracted by which many princes and sons of Nawabs had come there seeking her hands. But she chose none of them and they went away disappointed. It was the picture of this Sakhina that had turned the head of Firoj Khan who came there struck by her beauty, leaving his capital.

At this time Dewan Omar had fallen very seriously ill. Many a physician and Fakir failed to give him relief, though they had tried their best. The Dewan heard of the young Fakir and sent for him. When Firoj Khan received this invitation he was overjoyed at the opportunity thus given him for entering the Dewan's harem. Fakirs and Darbeshes were supposed not to know the wily ways of the world and had free access to Zenana.

Sakhina sat on the landing steps of the tank within the palace when Firoj Khan went thither responding to the Dewan's call. She was busy washing the red dye from her lovely feet. Her form reflected in the tank sparkled like the moonbeams on the waters. He at once recognised the maiden whom he had seen in the picture. "But the real is as remote from the picture as heaven is from earth," he thought. "It is not in the power of an artist to draw her exact likeness." Her beauty seemed like a lovely stream flowing down on all sides with its playful charms. When the young Fakir had come near

the bathing *ghat* Sakhina turned back and beheld him, "Ah me," she thought, "what a pity that this young man has renounced the world and turned a Fakir and left no chance for my making a choice!" She gazed at him with her insatiate eyes.

The maiden came up to him instantly and saluted him with the respectful folding of hands as was becoming before a Fakir and said, "Tell me, oh young Fakir, who you are! What disappointment did you suffer in life that has made you cut off all worldly ties and turn a Fakir? Where was seen a person of your tender age, who ever turned a Fakir? My heart melts in compassion for you. How could your parents allow you to leave home in this way? I wonder that they did not follow your track with the speed of a bird! Why is it that you have entered our harem?" Firoj Khan said in reply, "Your esteemed father, oh maiden, is seriously ill. He sent for me and I am here to try to cure him. It is by luck, fair maiden, that some people become kings; my humble lot is to be a Fakir. So you see I travel from one country to another as such."

Saying so he entered the hall where the Dewan Omer Khan lay in his bed. He gave him a charmed locket. Firoj Khan, after this, joined his army and shortly after returned home. (Ll. 1-146.)

(4)

After coming back he became a lover of solitude. He indulged in all sorts of reveries about the maiden Sakhina. He neither attended the Durbar nor did his duties as Dewan and hardly came out of his private chamber. One day he called the maid-servant Daria to his presence. Daria was a young girl of a lively temperament and looked bright with her smile when she spoke. She wore on her feet anklets of an artistic pattern call the 'Bakmal' and a

necklace which in the countryside they called 'Hàsli.' Her steps were graceful and she often laughed without a cause. She asked the Dewan as to what was the matter with him that he looked pale. "What a pity," she said, "that insects are already at work in such fine green bamboo-shrubs! If your lordship is willing to marry, I will travel all over the world to find a lovely bride for you. You have now stepped into youth, why should you thus deceive your own mind and deprive yourself of the pleasures which it is fit in the nature of things for you to enjoy"?

When the merry slave-girl thus delivered herself, Firoj Khan slowly said in reply, "Hear me, Daria, I sincerely believe that there is none in the world who sympathises with me more than you do. I have known you from childhood and I can place absolute confidence in you. I am going to open my mind to you to-day. I am feeling extremely miserable over the thought of my marriage. If you can help me to the attainment of my object I will reward you well. I will myself choose a good bridegroom for you and give you five maid-servants to wait upon you and minister to your comforts.

"You are to go from here to Kella-Tajpur in the guise of a picture-seller. There lives in that city princess Sakhina, the daughter of Dewan Omer Khan. You are to enter her harem with the pictures I will give you. Show her all of them one by one and last of all produce this picture of a Fakir and submit it for her inspection with due courtesy." Saying so the Dewan offered her a basketful of pictures which she took in her arms and was about to depart—after having salaamed him. The young Dewan asked her to stop for a moment and gave some further directions. He said, "Go to the harem

of Dewan Omer Khan, seeking a moment when Sakhina will be all alone in her room. Open your basket and let her know what she may be curious to learn from you. When you will show her the picture of the Fakir, keep your eyes fixed on her and study her face, closely observing what impression it makes on her. If she asks you anything in regard to that picture, tell her, 'I am a mere picture-seller and do not know much about him. I have only heard that he belongs to the family of Dewans. I have no detailed knowledge of the pictures that I sell, they are very numerous. I buy and sell them—that is my interest in them. I visited Delhi, Agra and other cities and last of all have come to Bengal. This picture of the Fakir I purchased on my way. I heard that this young man was a Dewan but has turned a Fakir enchanted with the beauty of a maiden named Sakhina, who it is said, lives in this very city—I have heard that he has been wondering from place to place like a Fakir maddened by her beauty.'

"You will say these words and observe if the colour of her face changes at this report."

Daria disguised herself as a picture-seller and started for Kella-Tajpur with the basket. It usually took a person three days to reach the city of Kella-Tajpur. Alone the slave-girl went all the way. She saw from afar the city with her crest of towers rising aloft to the sun and sparkling with their golden hue. The city covered a *pura* and a half of land. Every now and then did she see from distance blue-coloured tiara-shaped crests of Musjids fading as it were on the horizon. She admired the artistic skill and the plan of the city. The horses and elephants marched in the street with their riders on their gaily caparisoned backs; with eyes full of curiosity she observed everything as she proceeded.

On entering the palace she lost not a moment but instantly stepped into the harem and and saw Sakhina in her compartments. She was at that moment seated on a sofa in her room. Her dishevelled hair looked like broken clouds falling in profusion on the arms of the sofa. Daria beheld that unmatched beauty with wonder, and said to herself, "What is his fault? Even a woman would fall in love with such a maiden. How can a man resist such charms? I never saw a woman so beautiful. I wonder if in the land of fairies there is any to match her! How lovely are her feet decorated with the red dye! How exquisitely fine are her eyes painted with *surma*! With these eyes if she looks at any man he is sure to be maddened by her glance."

She saluted the princess and approaching her opened the basket of pictures. She first showed her the pictures of great emperors and kings and of great warriors. Next she showed her those of Nawabs and their Begums; and last of all she brought out from the basket the picture of the Fakir. She wiped away the dust and made it look bright. Then where the feet of the fair maiden decorated with the red dye *alta* rested on a foot-stool, she placed the picture with care.

She was startled at the sight, like one who had got a golden apple in dream or had met a very dear friend a real sympathiser—after the lapse of long years. And then keeping her eyes fixed on the picture she addressed Daria and said, "Now tell me, maiden, where did you get this picture? You have no doubt wandered about many strange places. Where is it, oh picture-seller, that such a one could be found? Who is the artist that has drawn this picture? And who is the person whose likeness it is? It seems that I once saw this Fakir. Tell me the plain truth without hiding anything."

She saluted Sakhina several times and said, "I will tell you, oh noble princess, all facts about this picture. My profession requires me to visit many places. I had been to Agra, Delhi and other countries. Last I came to Jangalbari where a merchant sold me this picture. I have heard from him this account of the Fakir. His name is Firoj Khan, he is the Dewan of Jangalbari. Oh my noble lady, this young Dewan is wandering about like a madman in the guise of a Fakir. At his absence the city of Jangalbari is in the deepest sorrow. The fair processions which on festive occasions attracted people from all countries to the city are no more to be seen there. The minister and high officers of State are all sad for their beloved Dewan. The subjects who love him dearly—the poor widows and others who live upon his charity—mourn for him shedding tears day and night."

Sakhina interrupted her in the midst of her speech and said, "I feel a deep compassion for the Fakir at what you have said, though he is a perfect stranger to me. Now, picture-seller, tell me if ever you met the Fakir and if you ever have heard why he has turned an ascetic. My heart weeps at the sorrows of the young Dewan. Will you tell me why he has left his palace and turned a Fakir? Tell me the whole story. I am purchasing the portrait with this my necklace. I will feel no rest until I hear the whole story."

Daria said, "I will tell you, oh princess, all that I have heard. This Fakir was formerly the Dewan of Jangalbari. It is said that in this fair city of yours there is a damsel named Sakhina, daughter of one Omer Khan. The young Dewan of Jangalbari struck with her beauty has turned a Fakir. What a pity that the Dewan is now a Fakir for the

sake of a waman, when he has just stepped into his youth !"

As she heard this account she became maddened with grief. She wiped away her tears with the edge of her *sadi*. Her mind became steeped in deep love. The *hasuli* which she wore on her breast was worth a lakh of rupees. She took it out from her neck and offered it to the picture-seller as reward. Daria saluted her and departed.

She held the picture close to her bosom and remembered the Fakir whom she had seen but once. She gave up her meals, her sleep and all joys. It seemed that her compartments looked dark without her smile. No more did that sweet smile play on her lips and no more did she sing sweetly like a bird ! On her couch no more did she allow flowers to be spread ! Her attendants—the maid-servants—were alarmed at the strange change that had come upon her. They could not guess what was it that weighed so heavily on her heart.

Thus the two lovers pined away for one another. And now I am going to relate to you the story of their marriage. (Ll. 1-174.)

(5)

Firoja Bibi, the mother of Firoj Khan, marked that her dear son was indifferent to the affairs of State and she called him to her presence. She said, " I have told you my mind times without number. I am resolved that you should marry now. If you do not marry, your line will end here and in this palace the evening lamp will not be lighted. This illustrious house of the Dewans, already looks gloomy, its splendour will go if you do not leave a scion behind you. Marry

as you would like, no one will interfere with your choice. But do not give pain to the poor old mother's heart. Do as I wish."

This time he did not oppose his mother. Silently he heard all that she said. He was inwardly pleased. He retired into the chamber and there he had a talk with the minister, he said to him, "I will open my mind to you to-day, oh Vizier. My mother is pressing me for marriage. Tell her that though I resolved not to marry, I will break my resolve for her sake. Tell her that there is a maiden named Sakhina, daughter of the Dewan Omer Khan of Kella-Tajpur. I am ready to marry her with the consent of my mother. If this maiden is not to be had as my bride, I will know that it is not the will of God that I should marry. So I will bear the pain of my heart secretly till I go to my grave."

On this errand did the minister seek an interview with the old queen in her apartment. He entered the inner apartment and saluted the old queen. She asked him what it was that had brought the old minister there. He saluted her again and said, "The young Dewan has at last given his consent to marriage. Omer Khan, the Dewan of Kella-Tajpur has a beautiful daughter named Sakhina. If this daughter could be secured for him, he would marry. If not, he would live a bachelor all his life."

The old queen after a pause said in reply, "Minister, I am really puzzled at this proposal. The Dewan of Tajpur, Omer Khan, is our sworn enemy. How can I make a proposal to him ? How can I think of making the daughter of our enemy the bride of this palace ? Go and tell this to Firoj. I will get for him a bride far more beautiful than Sakhina. My heart does not feel

any pleasure at the thought of this match. It will not be a happy one. I feel a misgiving. Tell him, oh minister, if he will allow me to choose a bride elsewhere. I shall be most happy to do so."

The minister saw the prince again and told him all that his mother had said and added, "If you marry this daughter of our enemy, all honour and status of your high position you will lose." The young Dewan replied, "You need not talk a good deal. If I cannot get Sakhina for my bride, I will remain a bachelor. I have turned like one mad after her. Her beautiful face is ever fresh in my memory. I do not want any other girl. And how can I do it? She is like the cool drink of my thirsty soul—the light of my eyes and the necklace of my breast. I want her. I do not want any one else. Tell my mother, if Sakhina is not to be had, here ends my life in the palace. I will go away turning a Fakir."

The Minister carried the message to the old mother. She fully realised the pain of her son's heart and thought within herself. "This son of mine is my sole stay. If he goes away, not a moment shall I be able to stay in the palace. For his sake, I can give up my life itself. Why should I stand in the way of his happiness? I will not oppose this marriage."

Thinking in this way the queen sent the old minister to Omer Khan, the Dewan of Kella-Tajpur with the proposal of marriage. It took the minister three days to reach the city of Dewan Omer Khan. He interviewed the chief who asked him, "From what country have you come here, oh Mian? What business have you with me?"

The old man saluted the Dewan Sahib of Tajpur respectfully and said, "I am the minister of Firoj Khan,

Dewan of Jangalbari. His mother Firoja Bibi has sent me to your Highness. It is known all over the country that you have got a very beautiful daughter named Sakhina, who has attained her marriageable age. Our young Dewan Sahib, Firoj Khan, for personal qualifications, handsome appearance and manly qualities, is second to none in the country. Firoja Bibi, his mother, wishes to ask you if you would consent to this marriage. I have been sent to you to make this proposal."

Omer Khan got angry at his words. Before the whole court he said in an indignant tone, "These Dewans of Jangalbari were originally Kafirs. They do not observe Roja (fast) and Namaj (prayers) like true Muhammadans. And indeed I do not count them as such. This proposal comes from a Kafir and hence I take it as an insult. This surely deserves a punishment." Saying this Omer Khan roared like a lion ; and instantly servants came from all sides to execute his order. He said, "Hold this old man by the neck and turn him out of the court."

Thus insulted the old man returned to Jangalbari.

(Ll. 1-116.)

(6)

Firoj Khan, the young Dewan Sahib, heard this story of the insult. As if the whole sea was set on fire, the young Dewan flew into a fit of rage, and at his command his officers made the public drums to be beaten in the city-markets ordering people to be ready with arms. "To-morrow they must be prepared for a great fight." This was the command. The generals came forward from all sides with their armies. The war-horses were caparisoned and bedecked with jewels and made ready. The army started and the sound arose in their ranks

"seize and kill." With a vast army Firoj Khan reached Kella-Tajpur the next day. They laid siege to the palace all on a sudden and forcibly entered it and seized the Dewan Sahib, his Uzir and other officers by their necks and drove them out from the city. The path was now quite clear and they entered the inner apartments. From her couch Firoj Khan raised Sakhina, imprisoned her and brought her to his own capital at Jangalbari. He was quite happy now and married her with her consent. Each was pleased with the other. They sat together and talked, walked together and were perfectly happy in one another's company. If one was sad, the other had no rest without sharing a part of it. They became steeped in love and enjoyed their nuptial life greatly at Jangalbari.

Let us drop here this topic and revert to the story of Dewan Omer Khan. (Ll. 1-26.)

(7)

Insulted and defeated by Firoj Khan, Omer approached the Emperor of Delhi. The Emperor was holding his Durbar as usual with his minister and high officers, and Dewan Omer Khan presented himself before him without any previous notice. The Emperor asked, "How is it, Dewan, that you are here all on a sudden? Your garments are not quite clean and your face looks pale and dark like a *kesar* fruit. Evidently you look worried. Now, tell me the reason of your sudden visit to our capital."

The Dewan saluted the monarch and said, "I have come here to lodge a complaint before Your Majesty. Be graciously pleased to hear all that I am going to submit. The present Dewan of Jangalbari is Firoj

Khan. He is born of a Kafir family ; but still he was so bold as to seek the hands of my daughter. He sent his minister with the proposal, and, as a matter of course, I dismissed him with refusal. He returned to Jangalbari and reported the matter to his chief. As a result the Dewan of Jangalbari laid siege to my capital with an army of 60,000 soldiers. My family, the members of my personal staff were all put to great humiliation. But this is not all. The worst that happened I am going to relate to Your Majesty. He drove away the female members of my house from the inner apartments and carried away my daughter Sakhina by force. There was none to save the poor girl from this disgrace. He married her by sheer force. With my heart as if pierced by an arrow I have come to lay my hard case before Your Majesty. I have no language to give adequate expression to the sense of my wrong. Maddened by grief I have come to the Durbar. I pray to Your Majesty to judge my case fairly. If I do not find justice here I will starve myself to death in this very palace of Your Majesty. It does not become one to live in this world after being so wantonly insulted by a Kafir."

The Emperor was angry at what he heard. His Majesty said in a loud voice before his court, "The Dewan of Jangalbari has, I see, become greatly conceited. He has ceased paying revenue to the State which is now in arrears for years. He does whatever he likes. Now, there should be an end of all such things. I will destroy him, his family and all, not sparing the children. Hear me, my ministers, send as large a force as available at this moment. The Dewan must immediately be arrested and brought here as a prisoner. When he will come here as a prisoner I will pass what judgment will be considered fit. (Turning to

Omer Khan) "You lead the army and go there to avenge yourself on the wrong committed on you."

The cavalry became ready and the warriors, riding elephants and horses, started with a vast following of foot-soldiers. The cry went on amongst the soldiers, "Be ready, start at once." The army consisted of a lakh of soldiers. The dust raised by their feet and horses' hoofs covered the sky. Some rode horses, others elephants; even the foot-soldiers vied to run apace with the cavalry. Omer Khan had the command of the army and rode foremost of all. The one lakh of army was a compact body, obeying their leader like one man. They all reached the precincts of Jangalbari and pitched their tents there.

On hearing the report of the arrival of this army Dewan Firoj Khan ordered the drums of his palace to be beaten, summoning his generals. They presented themselves before their chief in all haste with their armies. Firoj Khan robed himself as a warrior and went to the inner apartments to take his mother's permission to go to fight. (Ll. 1-62.)

(8)

Chorus—"Behold Firoj goes to the battle-field his mother's heart is pierced by the arrow of grief." He salutes his mother and says, "I am bound for war. Grant me permission, good mother. My town is under siege. Omer Khan has come down with the army of the Emperor determined to take revenge. Give me the dust of your feet, mother, and bless me. Don't, oh mother, detain me by your laments, lest the enemy takes advantage of my delay and enter the town."

The mother sorrowfully said in reply, "Don't, oh my son, go to war. Call your generals to the palace and

order them to fight. You are dear to me like the ribs of my breast. I shall not be able to live here alone sending you to the battle, I feel a misgiving that all will, perhaps, end in a disaster, and my heart throbs with fear at the thought of your going to the fight."

He hastily cut short the conversation by saying, "No mother, that cannot be. I must go to the battle myself. If I do not go, there is little hope of victory, My army will not be able to make a stand in the field in my absence. I assure you, I will come victor, my army will feel a new life if they see me at their head and fight to the best of their power. With a heart full of love for me they will zealously fight for their motherland and come off victorious. If I show them an example of cowardice, what will remain there to inspire them with courage in the field? Defeat will be sure at the hands of the enemy." Saying so he saluted his mother and touched her feet and, bidding adieu, left her presence.

Next, Firoj Khan went to the apartment of Sakhina to take leave. He addressed her saying, "Look here, dear lady, your beloved father has come here with the Emperor's army and I am bound for a battle with him. I have come to bid you farewell on the eve of the war. Take care of yourself. Pray, console my grief-stricken mother—what more can I say? The time is short—I must be off instantly."

On hearing this, Sakhina took a handful of sacred dust gathered from the shrines of five saintly men. He gently touched this sacred dust with his forehead. She then prayed that he might win the battle and come back without delay. The prince said, "By the grace of God, before the day closes, I will once more come back to your arms, dear Sakhina, as victor of the field."

Saying so he took leave and passed from sight. Sakhina looked at him from behind so far as she coulp stretch her eyes. Tears flowed from her eyes and she softly murmured, "Alas, I have made my heart stiff as stone, to allow him to go to the fight."

With his army, Firoj came to the field. For two incessant days the fight continued and the number of the dead was equal on both the sides. No party won, no party lost. On the third day, Firoj was made a prisoner. The enemy got hold of his person and carried him to Kella-Tajpur. The people of Jangalbari made loud lamentations at this issue of the war.

Chorus—"The horse returned with the flag unfurled on its back, stained with blood. When the lady saw this, her heart was about to break."

Sakhina lay on her couch, when all on a sudden, Daria, the female attendant, entered her room. When she saw Daria, she addressed her saying, "Day before yesterday, in the morning, my husband went to the field and now listen to me, oh friend Daria, gather the choicest of roses and champa flowers to weave garlands When he will return as victor, I will offer garlands as my presents of love.

"In the gold-plated toilet room, keep in reserve water for *auzu*, keep ready fans decorated with mica. We shall need offer him our services, when he will come back, a victor fatigued by fight.

"Keep in store rose-water and scented oil, and in golden cups keep sweet betels for my husband. Bring sacred dust, dear Daria, from the shrines dedicated to five saints. My husband, on return, will need bow to the sacred token.

"The wives of the saints have sent their blessings and assured me of my husband's victory."

As she said this her face brightened with a smile.

But she stopped a moment and said again, "Why is it, oh Daria, that you do not smile to-day? You look pale. But take my word, you will be happy on his return to the palace as victor."

Then Daria could no longer control herself but wept and said, "Now, lady, your luck is gone. The war-steed has returned with our flag, tinged with blood. It no longer becomes you, esteemed lady, to sleep on the couch."

"Come down and make your humble bed on the floor. Remove the red mark of luck from your forehead and the valuable rings from your ears. Change your costly *sadi* for a plain one and cut off your long flowing hair. From to-day you are to wear clothes befitting an ascetic.

"Remove your bracelets and other ornaments of the arm, and that bright necklace of diamond from your breast. The anklets with pendants should no more adorn your feet and you should also remove the jingling pendants from your belt. No more does that sweet smile befit your lips. Your beauty, your youth are now in vain. Alas, they are like flowers that bloom in morn to drop their faded petals in eve. News has come, dear lady, that your husband is now a prisoner at Kella-Tajpur."

When she heard this from Daria, she stood up in great emotion. It seemed to her that the sky itself had broken and fallen on her head. It was like a thunder-bolt falling on a garden of roses. The smile from her lips was gone and her heart seemed about to break. Her flowing tresses, unbraided, carelessly fell behind her back almost touching the ground. The maid-attendants, as they saw her grief, cried, 'alas, alas.' She addressed Daria and said, "My

good luck, oh Daria, is gone. But never mind, whatever may befall me, I do not care. Bring our war-horse instantly. I must see who is that enemy that could make *my* husband a prisoner. Make ready the horse for war and order the soldiers, the bow-men and the sepoys to be ready to follow me. I shall ride. I am a woman bound for war. This, please, oh Daria, keep secret for the present. If they ask you, 'Who it is that is going to lead us?' Tell them that a cousin of the Dewan is going to fight."

The elephants were caparisoned, the horses became ready. 'Be ready, be ready,' was the cry heard everywhere and the soldiers put on their war-robes in response.

Now Sakhina went to the apartment of her mother-in-law to take leave of her. She had left her couch and in great grief lay like one stunned on the floor. She consoled her mother-in-law by tender words, "Your hair is dishevelled and your face looks so pale, dear mother," Arise from the floor and give me permission to go to the battle-field at Kella-Tajpur. I will see what sort of hero is he,—who has dared lay hands on my husband and made him a prisoner. I will fight him and know his worth. Bless me, mother, that I may be a victor in the field and bring back your dear son home." The dowager queen wiped her tears away and addressing Sakhina said, "Grieved am I to hear of your resolve. My son, a warrior and a man, has become a prisoner, and you, a tender woman, will go to the battle! Who is it that has counselled you to take this mad course? You are the lamp of my house, precious to me as the prop is to the blind. For a moment I would not like to part with you.

I shall cease grieving for my son, drawing consolation from a sight of you. I cannot allow you to go to the battle-field."

Sakhina softly repeated her request for permission to go to the field saying, " Don't object, oh mother, but grant me this boon ; I assure you, I will come back a victor accompanied by my husband. If my luck turns hostile and I die in the battle-field—no grief, no sorrow will I feel in dying for my husband. For his sake I will give up my life. Adieu, dear mother, accept my humble respects at the hour of parting."

The mother-in-law and the daughter-in-law stood weeping, locked up in each other's arms for a moment. It seemed as if the golden city of Jangalbari became veiled in darkness.

The great war-horse Dulal, gaily caparisoned, stood ready in the inner compound of the palace and Sakhina jumped up on its back and rode with the speed of a flying bird. The van-guard rode in advance and other soldiers followed her, and the cloud of dust raised by horses' hoofs and the feet of the infantry covered a portion of the sky. The sun and the moon could not be seen in their proper time owing to the mass of dust raised in the sky. The birds left their nests and the animals ceased to graze in great fright. The journey which usually took a day was finished in 20 minutes as they proceeded on, and now before them stood the city of Kella-Tajpur. "My father is my enemy now," she thought and ordered the army to lay siege to the city. For two days and a half the parties fought with no decisive result. And Sakhina at this stage ordered her men to set fire to the city. Big palatial houses, great arches and doors were reduced to heaps of ashes. It was a great shame for the Emperor's troops that they became defeated at last. The afternoon passed and the sun peeped out from the western horizon. She was still fighting from the back of the war-horse with undaunted zeal.

At this moment came a messenger from the fort of Tajpur. He salaamed her and said, "A formidable warrior art thou, greater than Hanif himself. I come from Jangalbari, the enemies have destroyed the palace there. We do not know who you are, fighting in the interest of that ill-fated city. Here is a document which will shew the terms of amnesty signed by Dewan Firoj Khan who has sent me to you. He has asked me to convey the report to you that he has divorced the woman Sakhina for whom the golden city of Jangalbari has been ruined. He will meet all the rest of the demand made by the Emperor in course of a week. The war is at an end. This is the news which I have been ordered to communicate to you." Saying so, he handed her the document of divorce and she saw on it the impression of Firoj Khan's great seal.

A moment she took to read the document and then as if stung by a snake, she fainted and fell unconscious from the back of her horse. The golden crown on her head broke to pieces as she fell on the ground, and the great horse Dulal shed tears standing by her side. The soldiers began to cry and lament. Her seat a moment ago was on the back of her horse and now see her lying on the bare earth. It was as if the evening star had fallen on the earth from the sky. The city of Jangalbari now actually became covered with darkness. Her long dishevelled hair fell unbound on all sides. From her body fell the male's attire. The generals and soldiers at once recognised their queen and began to lament loudly. In the fort of Tajpur the report quickly spread, and Firoj Khan accompanied by Omer Khan at once visited the place. They came and saw the full moon—the golden moon—lustreless on the ground. Omer Khan took her in his arms and

just as a child cries taking the broken toy in his hands, began to lament over the body of his dear daughter. He said, " My doubts have all been cleared to-day. Had I known that things would come to such a pass, I would have myself sought for this marriage and taken the lead in all matters. Had I known all this I would have given the kingdom of Tajpur to Firoj Khan as dowry, and would have myself carried you to Jangalbari and offered you to its lord.

Dewan Firoj Khan addressed his minister and said, " I do not know what I have done to deserve this great calamity. Why should she have left me thus ! But I shall turn a Fakir for her sake. How can I console my poor mother ? No, here ends my connection with Jangalbari. No more would I care for the exalted position of Dewan Sahib. I am a Fakir to day. I shall sing songs in your praise, my love, and beg alms from door to door ! " He wept and said to his minister again, " Try to console my mother as best as you can. I am not going there. Her burial place will be mine too. I will sleep the eternal sleep there ; until I do so, I cannot think of getting any peace of mind." The minister wept and the great army cried in sorrow. Even the beasts of jungles and the birds of air shed tears at his sorrows.

The brave warriors sat down on the field of battle struck with grief and the report of this reached the city of Jangalbari.

Twenty-two spades-men dug a grave and after having performed the due rites such as the recitation of *Jánejá* they buried the body of Sakhina there. After burial they returned to their respective homes, carrying a deep sorrow in their hearts.

This song is finished and my audience may now depart. If I live I will come again next year to sing

to you, gentlemen, a new song. I do not know how to keep time, nor have I any musical instrument. I am afraid, my song will be found faulty in many ways. With my poor knowledge how can I expect to please such a distinguished audience as yourselves? Those who have sung chorus are all novices in the art of music, untrained and without any knowledge of the musical science. They have not been able to keep time and often struck discordant notes destroying the effect of the song. O, my esteemed President of this august assembly, forgive me for all my shortcomings. I bow down to you with great humility.

The master of the house, who bears the expenses of to-night's performance is Rang Miah. His name has justly got famous. He is a lucky man and is an inhabitant of Kajalkona. His great sympathy drew us to his home. I have received a reward from him, for singing this ballad of Firoj Khan. I have got *Dhuti* and *Chadar* and rice, —I beg to offer my thanks to him. May he flourish in wealth and may his children be long-lived and may he be happy with his sons and grandsons. May the fourteen *arahs* of land that he possesses yield rich crops from year to year. I pray for God's blessings on you, gentlemen. I shall now return home. May God fulfil your desires, amen! *Allah ho Akber.*

(Ll. 1-238.)

THE END.



Fig. I. A "Gadhu" boat.



Fig. II. The "Sarenga" boats at the Cháktái Ghat, Chittagong.



Fig. III. Modern Sloops built by the Bálámis.



Fig. IV. Modern Sloops built by the Bálámis.

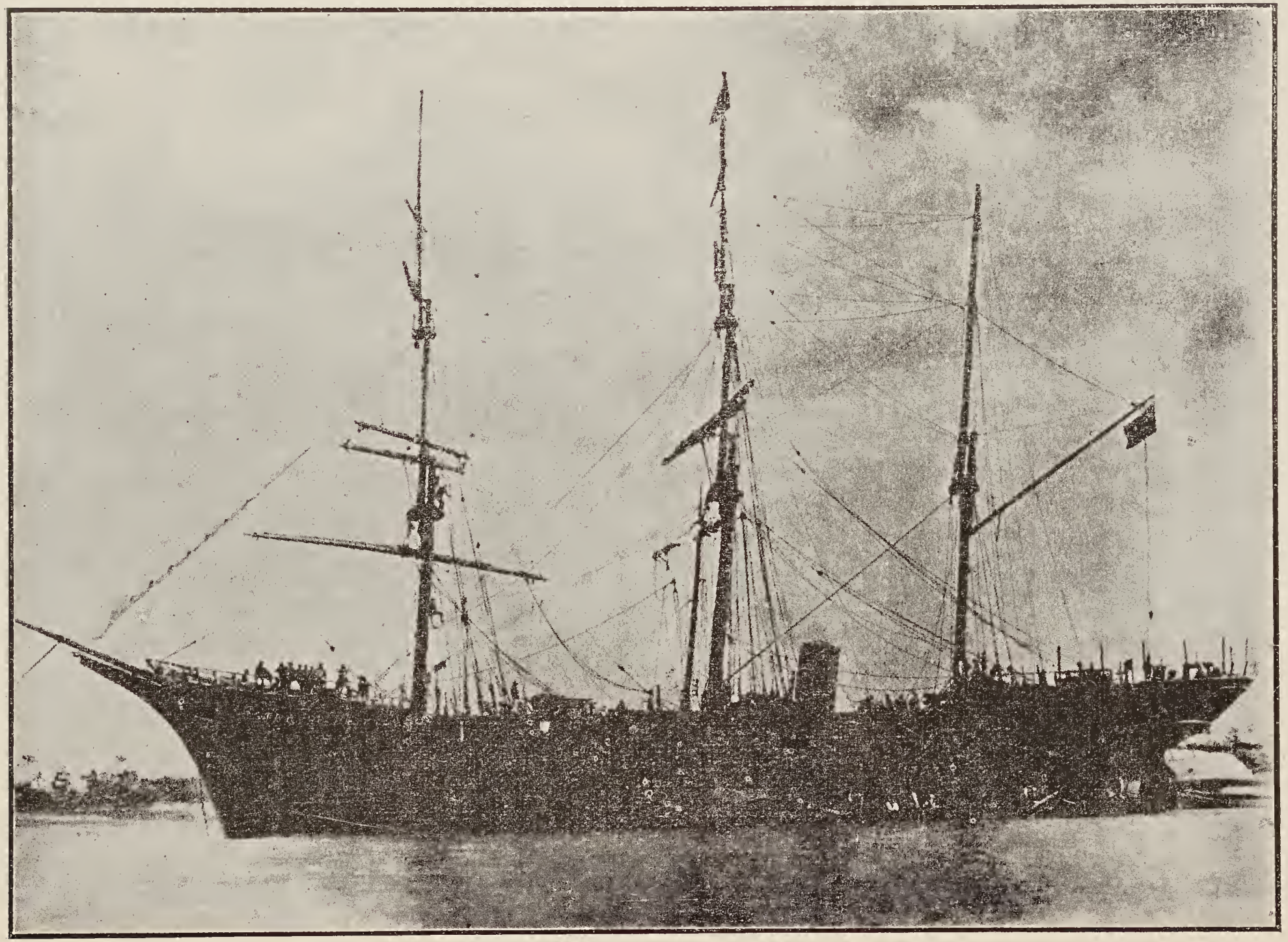


Fig. V. Modern Sloops built by the Bálámis.

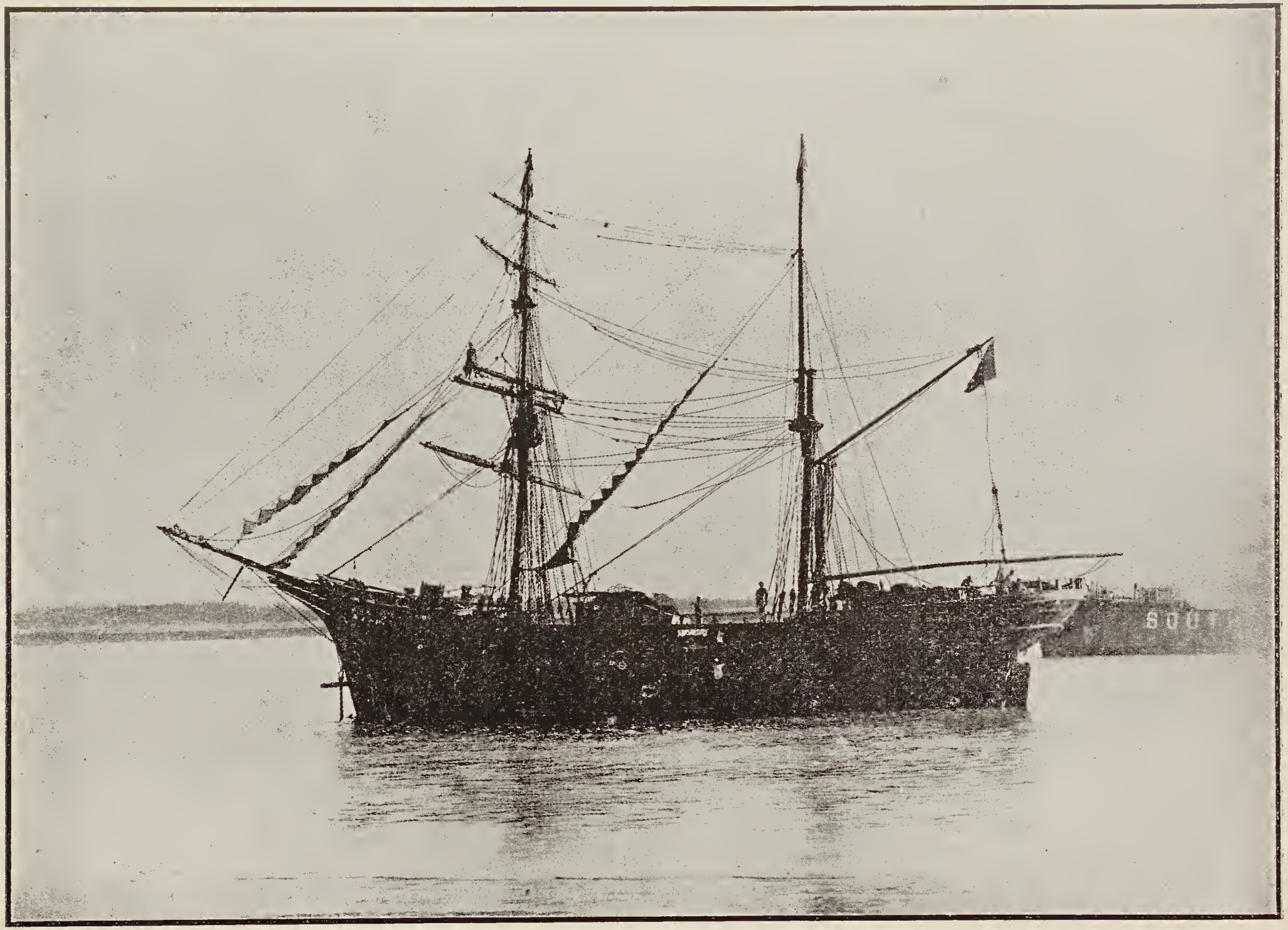


Fig. VI. Modern Sloops built by the Bálámis.



Fig. VII. Modern Sloops built by the Bálámis.

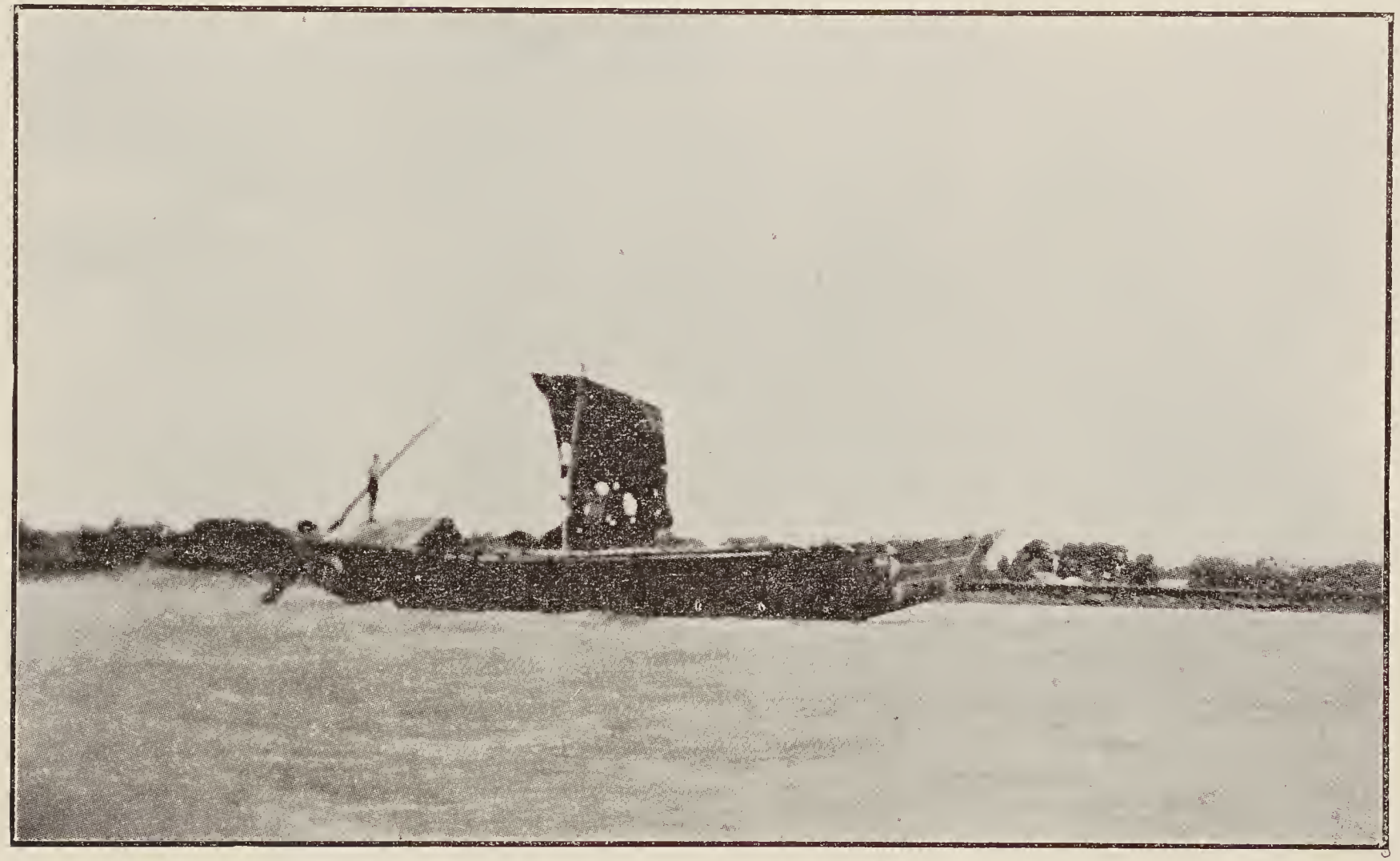


Fig. VIII. A Bálám boat of Chittagong.

INDEX.

INDEX

A

Abdarpur—264, 270.
Abdul (Dewan)—322.
Abdul Karim (Munshi)—35, 302, 309, 310, 334.
Abdul Khan—334.
Abdulla—283, 333.
Abdulla—373.
Ābir (red dye)—20.
Abruagunj—367.
Abul Fazl—301.
Abu Raja—131, 132, 135, 157-58, 163, 165, 168, 170, 172, 173, 175, 176, 178, 179, 181, 182, 186.
Achyut Bharan Tattanddhi—380, 382.
Adam (Khan, Mashnadali)—320, 325, 333, 353, 356, 360, 363.
Adam—381.
Adhar Chandra—189, 195, 205, 211.
Adhua—383, 389, 404, 406, 417.
Adunā—23.
Afghan—317.
Aguru—193.
Ahammad—330, 381.
Aini Akbari (also Ain)—301, 303, 307, 311, 365.
Aithor—79.
Ajib Gayen—424.
Ajjor Khan—373.
Aem Raya—370.
Akbar—314, 317, 327, 328, 347, 348, 368, 362, 370, 372.
Akbarnāmā—365.
Alangher char—186.
Alap Singh—349, 372.
Alal Khan—380, 388, 392, 393, 394, 411, 412, 413, 416.
Alaler Gharer Dulal—380.
Ali—283.
Alimurdian Khan—334.
Ali Noaz Khan—334.
Allahabad—369.
Alumni—365.
Āmāni—243.
Amarāvati (Rani)—313.
Amardighi—311, 317.
Amar Manikya—307, 308, 311, 312, 313, 314, 317, 325.
Amina—283.
Amir—217, 225.
Ananda Bazar Patrika—281.
Annals of Rural Bengal—261.
Aparājitā (flower)—10.
Arabia—329.
Arabian Nights' Tales—309.
Arabic—38, 363.
Ārāhs (measuring of land)—41.
Arang—58.
Asahebs—372.
Asalat Khan—373.
Asharia Mandal—35, 37, 51. 55, 56.
Ashraf Hossain (Muhammad)—122.

Ashtagrām—311.
Ashtamangal—120.
Assam—39, 137, 317.
Asutosh Chowdhuri—275, 331.
Atasi (flower)—19.
Atia—373.
Attar—363.
Aulia (Moslem Saint)—279, 281, 297, 298.
Azim Dād Khan (Dewan)—302, 366, 374.
Azim Ush Khan—330.

B

Baber—309, 310.
Babylonians—329.
Bacon—218.
Bahadur Ali Khan—334.
Bahadur Shah—305, 339, 368.
Bāhātiā—127.
Bāilākhāli—237, 238.
Baisakh—245.
Baiswara—304, 308, 328, 329, 368, 373.
Bajitpur—368.
Bāklā—311.
Baktiarpur—322, 324, 372.
Balarām—37, 42, 43, 44, 45, 50-54.
Balarām Sur—311, 314, 379, 383.
Barabaju—373.
Bana Durga—59.
Bangshidas—280.
Baniāchung—311, 384, 387, 388, 392, 393, 399, 411, 412.
Baradakhat—349.
Baruni—370.
Baradakhatmaura—349.
Bāramāsi—121.
Bara Pir Saheb—277, 295.
Bashkuli—263.
Baz Khan—313.
B. Buru—304.
Bechārām—266.
Bediyās—330.
Begum—320.
Behar—369.
Behari Lal Ray—215.
Bel—203, 234.
Benares—90, 92.
Bengal—34, 37, 122, 260, 294, 305, 307, 308, 311, 326, 329, 334, 369.
Besar (nose-ornament)—59.
Bhagirath Singh—304, 308, 337, 373.
Bhāndi-forest—270.
Bharāi—74, 86.
Bharāinagar—93, 104 116
Bhāratchandra—330.
Bhelua—33, 34, 129, 131-32, 135-41, 145, 147-48, 150, 152, 153-70, 172-73, 175-85, 187-88.
Bhowal—40, 311, 349, 372-73.
Bhulna—311.
Binni (paddy)—239.
Biram (Khan)—320, 323, 325, 356, 363.
Ben—374.
Birbhum—259.
Birsingpur—270.
Boāl (fish)—230.
Boālkhāli—275.
Boragar—270.
Brahmadaitya—221.
Brahmaputra—216, 221, 223, 232, 370.

Brahmins—136, 277, 321.
Brahminic Renaissance—122.
Brahmo Samāj—368.
British—216.
Buckergunje—311.
Budak'hal—320.
Bukāi—346.
Bulban Khan—334.
Bungalow—133, 346.
Burmese—39.

C

Candray—114.
Chai (plant)—240.
Chaitanya Bhāgavat—218.
Chaitanya Deva—218.
Champā (flower)—9, 10, 49, 59, 63, 128, 199.
Chānd—140, 151.
Chand Ray—311, 325, 327, 328.
Chandi—124, 417.
Chandidas—7, 8, 34, 167.
Chandrakumar De—6, 33, 40, 79, 191, 192, 379, 383, 387, 388.
Chandrakumar Sarkar—40.
Chandrahār (ornament)—128.
Chandrāvati—280, 387.
Chāpati—242.
Char Sambhuganj—6.
Chil (bird)—10.
Chirā—359.
Chirar moā—241.
Chittagong—33, 38, 57, 71, 72, 137, 275-78, 280, 331, 333, 345.
Chouddagrām—311.
Chou gangā—132, 172, 173, 175, 177-78, 184.
Christians—303.
Chua (perfumery)—208.
Chudder—234, 236, 245.
Cornwallis, Lord—960.
Cowrie—44, 216, 222.
Cupid—3.

D

Dacca—277, 301-2, 311, 315-16, 327, 345, 366-67.
Dakshinaranjan Mitra Majumdar—134.
Dakshin Bhag—381, 387, 405, 406, 409, 418.
Dargā—277, 278.
Darga Munshi—266.
Daria—425, 448, 450, 451.
Dāru—248.
Dāruk (tree)—80.
Darwesh—287.
Darzibazu—349.
Dasakāhaniā—222.
Dasamangal—120.
Daśamī—204.
Dashu—223.
Daud Khan—306, 307, 309, 310, 343, 344.
Dayāvanta Narain—312.
Delhi—193, 309, 317, 321-23, 325, 327, 344, 346-47, 369, 371-72, 388, 412, 413, 423, 429.
Demra—370.
Dewan *bāg*—316, 347, 370.
Dewan Bhābna—195.
Dewan family—301.
Dewans—305, 307, 309, 322-63, 365.
Dhananjaya—172, 187.

Dhān Durvā—156.
Dhanpat Singh (Raja)—304, 308, 337.
Dhoṛā—250.
Dhruva—84.
Dhuti—187, 245.
Digher-forest—285, 294, 296.
Dighi—328.
Dina Gopa—6.
Dingādhar—33, 35-37, 39, 41-45, 50-58, 69, 71, 73-76.
Divisional Commissioner—262.
Doā (fruit)—241.
Dôl (ceremony)—338.
Dôm (caste)—179-80.
Druid priest—425.
Dulal Khan—380, 382, 392, 393, 396, 403, 410, 411, 416, 417, 419, 451.
Dubaraja—381, 382, 404, 413.
Dulu—255-56.
Durbur—15, 109, 309, 346-48.
Durgā—162, 175, 204.
Durga Charan Sanyal—305, 320-21.
Durgā Pujā—42.
Durgotsava—338, 374.
Durvā—174.

E

Eastern Mymensingh—301.
Egāra Sindur—317, 326, 347.
Egypt—329.
Egyptians—329, 363.
Ehadali—334.
Enait Ali—334.
Eoz Mahamad—374, 424.
Echraj—374.
Essem Khan—119.

F

Fakir—53, 54, 285-90, 296-97, 341.
Fakir Faizu—379, 387, 408, 419.
'Farid's Spectacles'—278.
Fariduddin—280.
Fajilpur—424.
Fatehpur—40.
Fateh Khan—312, 316-17.
Fatemah Bibi—283, 306, 333, 392, 416.
Fengu Raja—33, 38.
Feroz Khan (Dewan)—217, 302, 319, 423, 424, 426, 432, 443, 444, 446, 447, 448, 453.
'Folk Literature of Bengal'—79, 134.

G

Gāchhuni Shaikh—40.
Gadi—324.
Gajadāni—318, 338, 368.
Gajamati—124.
Gajis—372.
Galāchipā—35, 302.
Gandharāj (flower)—154.
Ganeswari—128.
Gangamandal—349.
Ganjer Ghat—221, 238, 246, 253.
Ganjer hāt—222, 223.
Gangasagar—370.
Ganges—203, 327.
Garo (hills)—192.
Garos—39, 74, 81, 98, 193.
'Gari Tambi Mansavi'—193.
Gaur—337-39, 343-44.
Gayā (Shrine)—90, 92.
Gayā (name of a person)—40.

Gayārām—263.
Ghatak—152.
Ghorāghāt—327.
Ghyasuddin—303, 304, 310, 337.
Ghyasuddin Jalal Shah—305.
Ghyasuddin Muhammad Shah III—305.
Gilā (seed of scandre)—64, 199
Gilliatt—114.
Gitikathā—79, 134.
Goair—349.
Godhā—15.
Golak Viswas—40.
'Golden Book of India'—192.
Gonda—304.
Gopalgrām—40.
Gopis—8.
Governor General—262.
Govinda Dās—34.
Govinda Khan—279.
Gujir (ornament)—233.
Guno—123.
Guru—227.

H

Haibat Muhammad—330, 333, 334, 367, 374.
Haibatnagar—333, 365-68.
Habib Khan—379.
Haibatpur—320, 321.
Hajradi—367.
Halia ban—388, 393, 398.
Hanuman—269.
Hāoldar—267.
Hara Chandra Varmā—79.
Harikāl (birds)—247-48.
Harish Chandra—311.
Harishpur—321.
Haroun-al-rachid—369.
Hashan Ali—334.
Hayal—333.
Hazigunj—315.
Hazradi—349.
Hidayal—333.
Hijal (tree)—63, 66.
Hijra—317.
Himalayas—283.
Hindu—33, 38, 83, 136, 235, 276-77, 280-81, 319-21, 324.
Hinduism—318.
Hiraman—143.
Hiran—131-32, 162, 165-73.
'Holy Grail'—195.
Huen-t-shang—329.
Humayun—309, 323.
Hunter—261-62, 264.
Hussenpur—349.
Hussen Shah—304-06, 310.
Hussen Shahi—349, 367.

I

Ibn Batuta—278.
Ibrahim Khan—374.
Ibrahim Malik Ulema—306.
Ibrahim Ol Olema—368.
Ibrahim, Syed—372.
India—321.
Indra—211.
Ishā Khan (Dewan, Mashnadāli)—35, 299, 301-04, 306-18, 320, 322-23, 325-29, 333-45, 337, 343-53, 365-66, 423, 424, 427, 428, 429.
Ishāmati—284.
Ismail Khan—333.
I't Quid Khān—330.

Iwaz Muhammad—330, 333.

J

Jabbar—279, 291-93.
Jadunath Sarkar (Prof.)—281.
'Jahar Brata'—325.
Jaidhar Bāniya—119, 122.
Jainta (hills)—139, 162, 165.
Jainuddin—338-39, 368.
Jaiteswar—163-65, 168, 170, 175, 184.
Jalal Shah—306.
Jalal Shah Suri—333.
Jalaluddin—339, 342.
Jamait Ulla—217, 219, 246, 251.
Jamal Khan—381, 382, 384, 388, 389, 399, 403, 404, 406, 410, 412, 413, 414, 418.
Jamsher Khan—334.
Janakinath Mallik (Raja)—191-93.
Jangal bari—427, 428.
'Jangli Patsah'—290.
Jarail (wood)—285.
Jasimuddin (Munshi)—119.
Javā (flower)—65, 285.
Jaydevpur—311.
Jehangir—193, 320.
Jessamine—155.
Jhumkā (flower and ornament)—59, 233.
Jigā (hill)—97.
Jigatala—424.
Jnāna Das—34.
Joarshai—349.
Jodhbāi—320.
Jogir Gayen—424.
Journal of Asiatic Society, Bengal—301, 306, 316, 333.
Joyan Shai—349.
Jugaddal—40.
Jumma (bār)—252, 343.
Jumma—281.
Jungalbāri—299, 301-03, 307, 315, 317-19, 322-25, 330, 345-47, 349, 351-53, 355, 357, 359, 361-62, 365-70, 372.
Jungal Khara—367.

K

Kābab—342.
Kadamba (flower)—101.
Kadvi Jangal—367.
Kafirs—319.
Kāhan—222, 344.
Kaichar bāk—171.
Kailas Chandra Sinha—313.
Kajal Kona—454.
Kajjal—128.
Kālāpāhār—305.
Kāli—164, 270, 277, 354, 361.
Kālidas Gajdāni—302-06, 308-10, 318, 333-34, 338-43, 368, 427.
Kali Kumar Chakravarti—302, 333, 366.
Kalpataru—127.
Kamal Khan—381.
Kalu—250, 252-54, 256.
Kabe Shaikh—269.
Kāma—140.
Kāmākhyā—74.
Kamalādighi—191.
Kamalā rāni (Rani Kamalā Devi)—180, 191-93, 196-97.
Kamalāsāgar—191-93, 205.
Kamarali Khan—334.
Kambojis—136.

Kamoonir desh—39, 74.
Kanchan—[5, 11, 14, 21, 23, 24, 26, 28-30, 340] ; [80-82, 108-15].
Kanchanmālā—[3, 9, 10-13, 15, 16, 19-21, 26] ; [77, 79, 84-86, 92-99, 103-07, 109, 115].
Kanchannagar—131, 139, 141, 151-52, 156-58, 164, 176, 179, 183, 185.
Kanchanpur—126.
Kanu—225-32, 236, 249-50, 252-56, 290.
Kapistak—263, 266.
Kapta—342.
Kararain—310.
Karimgunje—367.
Karimulla—327, 355, 357-59, 361-62.
Karnafuli—277.
Kārtikeya—42, 151.
Kasturi—363.
Katghara—40.
Kati Khali—424.
Katrai—349.
Kausalyā—158.
Kavikankan—218.
Kāyastha—320-21.
Kazi—255.
Kedar Ray—301, 319, 323, 325-28, 349, 352-53, 356-62.
Kellā Tazpur—217,319,424,451-452.
Kenārām—280.
Kenduā—79.
Kangu Raja—75, 76.
Keoā (flower)—121.
Kerumulla—418.
Keshaver mār Dighi—318.
Khai—243.
Khaira—250.
Khaliajuri—349.
Khalisha (fish)—240, 243.
Khichuri—253.
Khilāt—314.
Khizirpur—316, 325, 327.
Khodabad Khan—334.
Khoda Newaz—374.
Khorāi—3, 17, 23, 28.
Killan Sadāgar—128.
Kishoregunj—40, 301-02, 333-34, 367.
Kirtankhola—6.
Koch—225, 227, 248.
Kai (fish)—240, 242.
Kóran—283.
Koshā—329, 349-50, 352-53, 361.
Krishna—8, 283, 338.
Krishnadas—264, 270-71.
Krishna Saha—268.
Krithivāsa—278, 280.
Krosha—329.
Kuch—238.
Kukis—39, 74, 81, 98.
Kulá—235.
Kulin—140, 151.
Kullar Abbas—40.
Kulpur—6.
Kumrabad—269-70.
Kunjalatā—81, 82, 98-105, 108, 110, 113, 115-16.
Kuṇkum—363.
Kurālyāmurā—284.
Kurikhai—349.
Kurmā—342.
Kusha (plant)—346.
Kushai—223.
Kutubuddin—301.

L

'La bella mal maridada'—122.
Lal Bāi—191-92.
Lal Khan—334.
Lakshman Hazra—315, 427.
Lakshman Singh—369.
Lakshmi—42, 59, 95, 140.
Lakshmindara—151.
Lalit Mohan Das—334.
Langal—266.
Laṇkā—269.
Latif—333-34.
Laur—269.
Lengra—390, 393, 394, 416, 417.
Lethbridge—192.
Līlā—84, 119.
Long (Rev. J.)—313.
Lowes, Mr.—366.

M

Machalandāni—314.
Machoom Khan—322, 324, 333-34.
Madan (God of Love)—338.
Madan—131-32, 139, 141, 143-44, 146-52, 156-58, 161, 163-66, 168-73, 177-79, 184-88.
Madan Byapari—425.
Madina—84.
Madhur Bāp—6.
Mahabat—333.
Mahesh Chandra Sarkar—40.
Maheswardi—349.
Mahomedan—33, 38, 136-37, 218, 273, 276-80, 302, 305, 313, 319-21, 327-28, 340-41, 343, 352, 354.
Mahamud Khan—381.
Mahomet—283.
Mahuā—33, 195, 387.
Mainamati-songs—276, 390.
Mainda—236.
Maishāl Bandhu—33.
Majhiya Shaikh—40.
Majlishi Jelal—372.
Majlishis—372.
Mālādhar—187.
Mālati (flower)—149, 154.
Maldah—162, 165.
Malilk-ul-ulma—372.
Mallikā (flower)—121, 154.
Maluā—84, 387.
Mamina Khatun—339, 341, 343.
Mān (esemlent plant)—12.
Manasa Devi—390.
Manshā Puja—121.
Mangal Chandi—45.
Manik—131, 139-40, 146-47, 151-52, 164, 171.
Maniktārā—215, 220, 236, 238-39, 244, 248-50, 250, 254, 255.
Mannowar ali—334.
Mannowar Khan (Dewan)—302, 315-16, 327, 330, 333-34.
Mannowar Khan Bāg—316.
Man Pavan—162, 165, 170, 175, 177, 179.
Man Singh—303, 317, 326, 328, 346-47.
Marichāli—79.
Marshman—365.
Mashnadāli—308-09, 314, 349, 368.
Mashnadali Itihāsh (Itihāsa)—302, 304, 306, 310, 320, 324, 335.
Match-maker—55.
Math—328.
Matiar Rahman—275.

Maulavi—362.
Maulvi Sahidullah—279.
Maurakshi—263, 265, 267.
Māydula—40.
Maynā—36, 73, 76.
Mazban Bhāti—301.
Mecca—387, 399, 410, 416.
Mecha (country)—199.
Medina—283.
Mediterranean—276.
Meghna—33, 39, 57-59, 71-76.
Menakā—132, 135, 166-68, 171-72, 176, 179-82, 184-85, 187.
Milton—133.
Mithā bish—219.
Moghul—309, 323.
Mollah—277.
Muga (pees)—243.
Muhammad—333.
Muhammadanism—318.
Muhammadan rule—216.
Muhammad Idris—366.
Muhammad Khan—372, 424.
Muhammad Shah Gazi—305.
Muhammad Toghluk—281.
Mujhis Jelal—329.
Murai—138-39.
Murapara—347.
Murari—131, 143, 146-47, 150-52, 156.
Murari Gupta—218.
Murighanta—243.
Musa—333, 424.
Mymensingh—6, 33, 39, 40, 80, 191-93, 215, 277, 302, 324-25, 329, 334, 365-67, 384.

N

Namasudra—40.
Nandalal Bose—367.
Nanoor—7.
Nārada—278.
Narayan Babu—379.
Narayangunj—316, 367.
Narsindha—367.
Nasaral Shah—305.
Nashir-u-Jilal—349, 367.
Nasirabad—278.
Nava Durga—88.
Nawapara—284.
Nazar Marichā—324.
Nazar marichar chhele—324.
Nelson Wright (H.)—305, 306.
Neter khuti—251.
Newaz Khan—374.
Nidhur Vyāpāri—40.
Nim—234.
Nimai Sanyas—381,
Niyāmat Jān—320, 352, 358.
Nizam (Dacoit)—273, 275-76, 279, 281, 283-90, 293-98.
Nizampur—278.
Nizamuddin—279, 281, 298.
Noakhali—277, 311.
Noapara—277.

O

Ochterloney Monument—329.
Omar Khan—319, 430, 442, 443, 444, 446.
Omedali Khan—334.
Orissa—369.
Oudh—304, 308.

P

Padmā (Manasā Devi)—174, 176.
Padmā (river)—327, 350-52, 359.

Patkara—349.
Palabuji—350.
Palasbari—252.
Pān—222.
Pancha—245, 255.
Panchamrita—88.
Panch Kahama—272.
Panchlish—278.
Pāpiyā (bird)—121.
'Paradise Lost'—133.
Pārul (flower)—128.
Pathan—312.
Patsah—291-92.
Payār—119, 216.
Pearpur—119.
Pererpur—263.
Permanent Settlement Act—260.
Persia—363, 384.
Persian—38, 306, 316, 385.
Phul bātāsā—239.
Phul Kumar—96, 100, 102, 110, 115.
Pir (Pir Saheb)—182, 277, 296-98.
Pirer kāndā—23.
Piriti—291.
Prāgjyotishpur—39.
Prahlād—84.
Pratapāditya—306.
Prologue—85.
Puja—200, 277.
Purah (measure of land)—161, 341, 402, 428.
Puranas—84.
Puthi (fish)—240.

R

Rādhā—47, 283.
Raghunath—192, 284.
Raghunath Singh—192-93.
Rahaman Gayen—424.
Rahim Dad Khan—374.
Rāhu—14.
Rajanikanta Bhadra—6.
Rajarbāg—370.
Rajbāri—327.
Rajchandra Ghosh (Munshi)—302, 333, 336.
Rajdhara (Prince)—312, 315-16.
Rajdighi—251.
Rajmālā—307-08, 311, 313-14.
Rajmohul hills—264, 268.
Rajtikā—96.
Rajvamshis—136.
Rakshasa—60, 74.
Ralph Fitch—303.
Rama—83.
Rāmāyana—278, 280.
Ramgopalpur—192.
Ram Hazra—315.
Ramkumar Mistri—79.
Ram Lakshman (conch-bracelet)—126, 345.
Ram Ram Vasu—306.
Ram Sankar Sen (Rai Bahadur)—368.
Rana Bhowal—311.
Rangamati—370.
Rang Miah—454.
Rāngchāpur—39, 131-32, 157-58, 165, 167.
Ranjan—277.
Rashis (distance)—362.
Rati—140, 149.
Ratnakar—78.
Rāunya—284.
Rāvan—180.

Rāyer Bazar—40.
R. C. Dutt, Mr.—366.
Renaissance—136.
Robikul—283.
Rosul—283.
Rowail—372.
Rui (fish)—240.
Rukmini—5, 18-21.

S

Sadar Ali Gāyen—275.
Sadgopas—269.
Sādh—88.
Sadhu—87, 89.
Sadhu Das—269.
Sadhu Sil—236, 239-40, 242-45.
Saḍi (also spelt *sari*)—50, 51, 54, 57, 59, 64, 67, 73, 74, 96, 160, 179-81, 199, 201, 203, 207, 209, 211, 233, 237, 329, 340, 363.
Sadipur—266.
Sadir Gayen—424.
Sahajiyā—122.
Sākhinā—217, 331, 425, 447, 451.
Sāl (wood)—208.
Sāli (harvest)—17, 121.
Salim Khan—301.
Salukā—152-54, 164-65, 180, 182, 184-86, 188.
Samsher Khan—334.
Sanad—348-49.
Sānāi (flute)—56.
Sankanda—6.
Sankar—179.
Sankha (river)—284.
Sankhapur—131, 138, 146-47, 150-52, 156, 183, 186-87.
Sankhini—250.
Sannyāsi—82, 91-94, 104, 107-08, 111-13, 277.
Santal—257, 259-71.
Santi—117, 119-20, 123-28.
Sarail (Pergannah)—307, 311-12, 314-15.
Sāri (bird)—149, 152-53, 155,162, 165, 168-71, 178, 182-83, 185, 200.
Sati (rites)—191.
Saturn—139.
Satyayuga—193.
Saurendra Kishore Ray Chaudhuri—192.
Sayabali Gāyen—424.
Sepoys—263.
Sepulveda's collections—122.
Setar—374.
Seyāt (vessel)—205.
Shadhan—349.
Shahbatpur—320.
Shah Baz Khan—303, 312, 315, 322, 324, 344.
Shah Jehan—330.
Shah Neoaz (Khan, Dewan)—366.
Shah Suja—330-31.
Shahen Shah—369.
Shaikh Farid—278, 285, 288-89, 294, 297-98.
Shail (fish)—230.
Shakespeare—121.
Shāknāibāttā—6.
Sharfarāli—367.
Sharif—333-34.
Shastras—341.
Sherpur—222, 346, 349.
Sher Shah—305, 316-17.

Shylock—35, 37.
Simul (tree)—237-38.
Sinda—349.
Singākhāli—39, 41, 45, 52-53.
Singāpur—39, 42, 44, 53, 56.
Singi (fish)—241.
Sitā—60, 107, 284.
Sitaghāt—284.
Siva—74, 203.
Siva Ratan Mitra—259.
'Social History of Bengal'—305, 320.
Sodhorām—312.
Sohāgi—40.
Soloman Khan—369.
Somai—199.
Someswari—192.
Sonakandi—432.
Sona Mājhi—230.
Sona Mani—303, 319-20, 325, 424.
Sonārgāon—303.
Soorma Valley—137.
Sovan Dad Khan (Dewan)—302, 366.
Spanish ballad—122.
Sripur—325, 327, 349, 351-52, 354, 357-62.
Stapleton (Mr. H. E.)—301, 304, 314, 316, 320, 324, 328, 333, 335.
Suā—207.
Subādār—267.
Subha Babu—262, 265, 268.
Subhadrā—303, 319-20, 324-25, 352.
Subuddhi Narayan—311.
Sujati—33-35, 39, 46, 50, 54-57, 59, 60, 76.
Suka—143, 146-49, 153, 162, 178, 182-83, 185, 200.
Suktā—243.
Sulaiman Kararani—304-07, 309.
Sulaiman Khan—305-06, 309-10, 333-34, 343, 368.
Sultan—343-44.
Sultan Bazed Bostani—278.
Sumāru—248.
Sundar—295-96.
Sundhā Methi—80, 97.
Suri—259.
Surmai—39, 57, 63, 74.
Susang Durgāpur—191-92.
Sutrakona—40.
Suvarna Grām—335, 349.
'Suvarna Grāmer Itihāsa'—325, 334.
Swarnamayee—319.
Swarup Chandra Ray—325, 334-35.
Syer-ul-Mutakherim—365.
Sylhet—122, 311-12, 317.

T

Tagar (flower)—155.
Tamshā Gazi—6, 23, 24.
Tārā—246-49, 251, 254-56.
Tarap—312, 316-17, 372.
Taziuddin Gada—369.
Taz Khān—301, 313.
'Tazkiratul Aulia'—280.
Tera Lengra—390, 393, 402.
Thakur—321.
'Thakurdadar Jhuli'—134.
'The Ill-married Lady'—122.
Tiārā (ornament)—128.
Tiler lāru—241.
Tinkari—218, 234.
Tipperah—219, 307-08, 311-15, 317, 321, 325.

Titash (river)—315.
Toghlakabad—281.
'Toilers of the Sea'—114.
Tokā—128.
Tulsi—234.
Turan—301, 307, 311.

U

Uchhigrām—40.
Udaypur—312.
Udaypur hills—311, 317.
Ujani—138, 143, 146-47, 151, 180.
Ulki—242.
Umad Ali—334.
Urdu—38.
Urumberia (a low caste)—55.

V

Vaishnavas—8, 34.
Vālmiki—278.
Varendra Brahmins—205.
Vashu—220, 223-25, 227-37, 239-46, 248-49, 251-54.
Venus and Adonis—121.
Victor Hugo—114.
Vidyādhara—98.
Vikramaditya—306.
Vikrampur—301, 311, 325, 327.
Vishnu—223-24, 239.
Vizir—291-92.
Vrindavana—283.

W

Washer-Maiden—1, 3, 6, 34, 195.
Western Bengal—259.
Wise (Dr. James)—301, 303, 305, 310, 316, 318, 321, 324, 328, 330, 335, 365.

Y

Yayāti—307.
Yuvarāja—321.

Z

Zeminder—50, 311.

OPINIONS

"HISTORY OF THE BENGALI LANGUAGE AND LITERATURE" (IN ENGLISH)

By

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From a review in DEUTSCHE RUNDSCHAN, April, 1912 —" The picture which this learned Bengali has painted for us with loving care of the literature of his native land deserves to be received with attentive and grateful respect."

From a review in LUZAC'S ORIENTAL LIST, London, May-June, 1912—" A work of inestimable value, full of interesting information, containing complete account of the writings of Bengali authors from the earliest time...It will undoubtedly find a place in every Oriental Library as being the most complete and reliable standard work on the Bengali Language and Literature."

From a review in the INDIAN MAGAZINE, London, August, 1912—" For Mr. Sen's erudition, his sturdy patriotism, his instructive perception of the finer qualities in Bengali life and literature, the reader of his book must have a profound respect if he is to understand what modern Bengal is."

From a long review in the MADRAS MAIL, May 9, 1912 —" A survey of the evolution of the Bengali letters by a student so competent, so exceptionally learned, can hardly fail to be an important event in the world of criticism."

From a long review in the PIONEER, May 5, 1912— " Mr. Sen is a typical student such as was common in mediæval Europe—a lover of learning for learning's sake...He must be a poor judge of characters who can rise from a perusal of Mr. Sen's pages without a real respect and liking for the writer, for his sincerity, his industry, his enthusiasm in the cause of learning."

Extract from a long review by Sylvain Levi (Paris) in the REVUE CRITIQUE, Jan. 1915 ; (translated for the Bengalee)—

" One cannot praise too highly the work of Mr. Sen. A profound and original erudition has been associated with a vivid imagination. The works which he analyses are brought back to

life with the consciousness of the original authors, with the movement of the multitudes who patronised them and with the landscape which encircled them. The historian, though relying on his documents, has the temperament of an epic poet. He has likewise inherited the lyrical genius of his race. His enthusiastic sympathy vibrates through all his descriptions. Convinced as every Hindu is of the superiority of the Brahmanic civilization, he exalts its glories and palliates its shortcomings, if he does not approve of them he would excuse them. He tries to be just to Buddhism and Islam; in the main he is grateful to them for their contribution to the making of India. He praises with eloquent ardour the early English missionaries of Christianity.

The appreciation of life so rare in our book-knowledge, runs throughout the work; one reads these thousand pages with a sustained interest; and one loses sight of the enormous labour which it presupposes; one easily slips into the treasure of information which it presents. The individual extracts quoted at the bottom of the pages offers a unique anthology of Bengali. The linguistic remarks scattered in the extracts abound in new and precious materials. Mr. Sen has given to his country a model which it would be difficult to surpass; we only wish that it may provoke in other parts of India emulations to follow it.''

From a review in the ENGLISHMAN, April 23, 1912—'' Only one who has completely identified himself with the subject could have mastered it so well as the author of this imposing book.''

From a review in the EMPIRE, August 31, 1918—'' As a book of reference Mr. Sen's work will be found invaluable and he is to be congratulated on the result of his labours. It may well be said that he has proved what an English enthusiast once said that 'Bengali unites the mellifluousness of Italian with the power possessed by German for rendering complex ideas.' ''

From a review by F. G. PARGITER in the INDIAN ANTIQUARY, December, 1912—'' This book is the outcome of great research and study, on which the author deserves the warmest

praise. He has explained the literature and the subjects treated in it with such fulness and in such detail as to make the whole plain to any reader. The folk-literature, the structure and style of the language, metre and rhyme, and many miscellaneous points are discussed in valuable notes. The tone is calm and the judgments appear to be generally fair.''

BANGA SAHITYA-PARICHAYA

OR

TYPICAL SELECTIONS FROM OLD BENGALI LITERATURE.

BY

Prof. Dineschandra Sen, Rai Bahadur, B.A., D.Litt.

2 vols, Royal 8vo, pp. 1914, with an Introduction in English running over 99 pages, published by the University of Calcutta.

(With 10 coloured illustrations. Price Rs. 18.)

SIR GEORGE GRIERSON—'' Invaluable work.....That I have yet read through its 1900 pages I do not pretend, but what I have read has filled me with admiration for the industry and learning displayed. It is a worthy sequel to your monumental History of Bengali Literature, and of it we may safely say '*finis coronat opus*.' How I wish that a similar work could be compiled for other Indian languages, specially for Hindi.''

E. B. HAVELL—'' Two monumental volumes from old Bengali Literature. As I am not a Bengali scholar, it is im-

possible for me to appreciate at their full value the splendid results of your scholarship and research, but I have enjoyed reading your luminous and most instructive introduction which gives a clear insight into the subject. I was also very much interested in the illustrations, the reproduction of which from original paintings is very successful and creditable to Swadeshi work.''

H. BEVERIDGE—'' Two magnificent volumes of the Banga Sahitya-Parichaya.....I have read with interest Rasa Sundari's autobiography in your extracts.''

F. H. SKRINE—'' The two splendid volumes of Banga Sahitya-Parichaya I am reading with pleasure and profit. They are a credit to your profound learning and to the University which has given them to the world.''

From a long review in THE TIMES LITERARY SUPPLEMENT, London, November 4, 1915—'' In June, 1912, in commenting on Mr. Sen's History of Bengali Language and Literature, we suggested that work might usefully be supplemented by an anthology of Bengali prose and poetry. Mr. Sen has for many years been occupied with the aid of other patriotic students of the mediæval literature of Bengal in collecting manuscripts of forgotten or half-forgotten poems. In addition to these more or less valuable monuments of Bengali poetic art, the chief popular presses have published great masses on literary matter, chiefly religious verse. It can hardly be said that these piles of written and printed matter have ever been subjected to a critical or philological scrutiny. Their very existence was barely known to the Europeans, even to those who have studied the Bengali Language on the spot. Educated Bengalis themselves, until quite recent times, have been too busy with the arts and sciences of Europe to spare much time for indigenous treasures. That was the reason why we suggested the compiling of a critical chrestomathy for the benefit not only of European but of native scholars. The University of Calcutta prompted by the eminent scholar Sir Asutosh

Mookerjee, then Vice-Chancellor, had already anticipated this need it seems. It had shrunk (rightly, we think) from the enormous and expensive task of printing the MSS. recovered by the diligence and generosity of Mr. Sen and other inquirers and employed Mr. Sen to prepare the two bulky volumes now before us. The Calcutta Senate is to be congratulated on its enterprise and generosity.''

From a review in The ATHENÆUM, January 16, 1915—'' We have already reviewed Mr. Sen's History of Bengali Language and Literature and have rendered some account of his previous work in Bengali entitled *Banga Bhasa O Sahitya*. Mr. Sen now supplies the means of checking his historical and critical conclusions in a copious collection of Bengali verse.....Here are the materials carefully arranged and annotated with a skill and learning such as probably no one else living can command.''

From a review by Mr. F. G. PARGITER—in the *Royal Asiatic Society's Journal*—'' These two portly volumes of some 2,100 pages are an anthology of Bengali poetry and prose from the 8th to the 17th century and are auxiliary to the same author's History of Bengali Language and Literature which was reviewed by Mr. Beveridge in this Journal for 1912.....The Vice-Chancellor of the Calcutta University who was consulted, decided that the best preliminary measure would be to make and publish typical selections. The University then entrusted that duty to Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen; this work is the outcome of his researches. There can be no question that Dinesh Babu was the person most competent to undertake the task and in these two volumes we have without doubt a good presentment of typical specimens of old Bengali literature.....The style of the big book is excellent, its printing is fine, and it is embellished with well-executed reproductions in colour of some old paintings. It has also a copious index.

THE VAISNAVA LITERATURE OF MEDIÆVAL BENGAL

[Being lectures delivered as Reader to the University of Calcutta.]

BY

RAI SAHIB DINESH CHANDRA SEN, B.A.

Demy 8vo, 257 pages

WITH A PREFACE BY

J. D. ANDERSON, Esq., I.C.S. (*Retired*)

Price Rs. 2

SIR GEORGE GRIERSON—"Very valuable book.....I am reading it with the greatest interest and am learning much from it."

WILLIAM ROTHENSTEIN—"I was delighted with your book, I cannot tell you how touched I am to be reminded of that side of your beloved country which appeals to me most—a side of which I was able to perceive something during my own too short visit to India. In the faces of the best of your countrymen I was able to see that spirit of which you write so charmingly in your book. I am able to recall these faces and figures as if they were before me. I hear the tinkle of the temple-bells along the ghats of Benares, the voices of the women as they sing their sacred songs crossing the noble river in the boats at sunset and I sit once more with the austere Sanyasin friends I shall never, I fear, see more. But though I shall not look upon the face of India again, the vision I had of it will fill my eyes through life, and the love I feel for your country will remain to enrich my own vision of life, so long as I am capable of using it. Though I can only read you in English, the spirit in which you write is to me so true an Indian spirit, that it shines through our own idiom, and carries me, I said before, straight to the banks of your sacred rivers, to the bathing tanks and white shrines and temples of your well-remembered villages and tanks. So once more I send you my thanks for the magic carpet you sent me, upon which my soul

can return to your dear land. May the songs of which you write remain to fill this land with their fragrance; you will have use of them, in the years before you, as we have need of all that is best in the songs of our own seers in the dark waters through which we are steering.''

The Vaisnava Literature of Mediæval Bengal. By Rai Sahib Dineschandra Sen. (The Calcutta University.)

'' Though the generalisation that all Hindus not belonging to modern reform movements are Saivas or Vaisnavas is much too wide, there are the two main divisions in the bewildering mass of sects which make up the 217,000,000 of Hindus, and at many points they overlap each other. The attempts made in the 1901 Census to collect information regarding sects led to such unsatisfactory and partial results that they were not repeated in the last decennial enumeration. But it is unquestionable that the Vaisnavas—the worshippers of Krishna—are dominant in Bengal, owing to the great success of the reformed cult established by Chaitanya, a contemporary of Martin Luther. The doctrine of Bhakti or religious devotion, which he taught still flourishes in Bengal, and the four lectures of the Reader to the University of Calcutta in Bengali here reproduced provide an instructive guide to its expression in the literature of the country during the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. The first part of the book is devoted to the early period of Vaisnava literature, dating from the eleventh century.

The Rai Sahib is filled with a most patriotic love of his nation and its literature, and has done more than any contemporary countryman to widen our knowledge of them. His bulky volume recording the history of Bengali Language and Literature from the earliest times to the middle of the nineteenth century is accepted by Orientalists as the most complete and authoritative work on the subject.

There is refreshing ingenuousness in his claim, 'my industry has been great,' and the 'forbearing indulgence' for which he asks if he has failed from any lack of powers, will readily

be granted in view of the enthusiasm for his subject which somewhat narrows the strictly critical value of his estimates, but does not impair the sustained human interest of the book.

Chaitanya clearly taught, as these pages show, that the Krishna of the Mahabharata, the great chieftain and ally of the Pandava brothers, was not the Krishna of Brindaban. The latter, said the reformer, to Rupa, the author of those masterpieces of Sanskrit drama, the Vidagdha Madhava and the Lalita Madhava, was love's very self and an embodiment of sweetness : and the more material glories of Mathura should not be confused with the spiritual conquests of Brindaban. The amours of Krishna with Radha and the milkmaids of Bridaban are staple themes of the literature associated with the worship of the God of the seductive flute. But Mr. Sen repeatedly insists that the love discussed in the literature he has so closely studied is spiritual and mystic, although usually presented in sensuous garb. Chaitanya who had frequent ecstasies of spiritual joy, Rupa, who classified the emotions of love in 360 groups and the other authors whose careers are here traced were hermits of unspotted life and religious devotion. The old passionate desire for union which they taught is still dominant in modern Bengali literature not directly Vaisnava in import. As Mr. J. D. Anderson points out in his preface, the influence of Chaitanya's teaching may be detected in the mystical verses of Tagore.''

From a long review in the TIMES LITERARY SUPPLEMENT, 26th April, 1918 :—(Mediæval Vaisnab Literature.)

'' This delightful and interesting little book is the outcome of a series of lectures supplementing the learned discourses which Mr. Sen made the material of his ' Baisnava Literature of Mediæval Bengal ' reviewed by us on August 2, 1917.

It is an authentic record of the religious emotion and thought of that wonderful land of Bengal which few of its Western rulers, we suspect, have rightly comprehended, not from lack of friendly sympathy but simply from want of precisely what Mr. Sen better than any one living, better than Sir Rabindranath Tagore himself, can supply.

It is indeed, no easy matter for a Western Protestant to comprehend, save by friendship and sympathy with just such a pious Hindu as Mr. Sen, what is the doctrine of an *istadevata*, a 'favourite deity' of Hindu pious adoration. In his native tongue Mr. Sen has written charming little books, based on ancient legends, which bring us very near the heart of this simple mystery, akin, we suppose, to the cult of particular saints in Catholic countries. Such for instance, is his charming tale of 'Sati,' the Aryan spouse of the rough Himalayan ascetic God Siva. The tale is dedicated, in words of delightfully candid respect and affection, to the devoted and loving wives of Bengal, whose virtues as wives and mothers are the admiration of all who know their country. Your pious Vaisnava can, without any hesitation or difficulty, transfer his thoughts from the symbolical amorism of Krishna to that other strange creation-legend of Him of the Blue Throat who, to save God's creatures, swallowed the poison cast up at the Churning of the Ocean and bears the mystic stigma to this day. Well, we have our traditions, legends, mysteries, and as Underhill and others tell us, our own ecstatic mystics, who find such ineffable joy in loving God as, our Hindu friends tell us, the divine Radha experienced in her sweet surrender to the inspired wooing of Krishna. The important thing for us, as students of life and literature, is to note how these old communal beliefs influence and develop that wonderful record of human thought and emotion wrought for us by the imaginative writers of verse and prose, the patient artists of the pen.

When all is said, there remains the old indefinable charm which attaches to all that Dines Chandra Sen writes, whether in English or his native Bengali. In his book breathe a native candour and piety which somehow remind us of the classical writers familiar to our boyhood. In truth, he is a belated contemporary of, say, Plutarch, and attacks his biographical task in much the same spirit. We hope his latest book will be widely (and sympathetically) read."

J. D. ANDERSON, Esq., retired I.C.S., Professor, Cambridge University :—"I have read more than half of it. I propose to send

with it, if circumstances leave me the courage to write it, a short Preface (which I hope you will read with pleasure even if you do not think it worth publication) explaining why, in the judgment of a very old student of all your works, your book should be read not only in Calcutta, but in London and Paris, and Oxford and Cambridge. I have read it and am reading it with great delight and profit and very real sympathy. Think how great must be the charm of your topic and your treatment when in this awful year of anxiety and sorrow, the reading of your delightful MS. has given me rest and refreshment in a time when every post, every knock at the door, may bring us sorrow.''

JULES BLOCH—'' I have just finished the romantic story of Chandravati (given in the Bengali Ramayanas). May I congratulate you on the good and well deserved luck of having discovered her after so many others and having added that new gem to the crown of Bengali Literature.

I cannot speak to you in detail of your chapters on the characteristics of the Bengali Ramayanas and on Tulsidas, I had only to learn from what you say and thank you for helping me and many others to get a little of that direct understanding and feeling of the literary and emotional value of those poems in general and Krittivas in particular. I hope your devotion to Bengali Literature will be rewarded by a growing popularity of that literature in India and in Europe; and also that young scholars will follow your example and your direction in continuing your studies, literary and philological.''

SIR GEORGE GRIERSON—''I must write to thank you for your two valued gifts of the '' Folk Literature of Bengal '' and '' The Bengali Ramayanas.'' I delayed acknowledging them till I had read them through. I have been greatly interested by both, and owe you a debt of gratitude for the immense amount of important information contained in them.

I add to this letter a few notes which the perusal of your books has suggested to me. Perhaps you will find them useful.

I hope that you will be spared to us to write many more such books.''

Dr. WILLIAM CROOKE, C.I.E., EDITOR OF '' FOLK LORE ''—'' I have read them (' Folk Literature of Bengal ' and ' The Bengali Ramayanas ') with much interest. They seem to me to be a very valuable contribution to the study of the religion and folk-lore of Bengal. I congratulate you on the success of your work and I shall be glad to receive copies of any other work which you may write on the same subjects.''

H. BEVERIDGE—'' Of the two books I must say that I like best the Bengali Ramayanas. Your book on Bengali folk lore is also valuable '' (from a letter of 12 pages containing a critical review of the two books).

From the ''*Revista Trimestrale di studi Filosofici e Religiosi*''

Rai Bahadur Dineshchandra Sen's Folk Literature of Bengal.

—'' The University of Calcutta continues with every alacrity, the fine series of its publications thus testifying to the high scientific preparation (issuing out) of those indigenous teachers. This volume devoted to the popular tales of Bengal also constitutes a contribution of the first rank to such a subject. The tracing of the History of the Bengali language and literature in this University is one of the most well-deserved studies of Bengal. To it is due, in fact, the monumental and now classical History of the Bengali Language and Literature (1912);—in which, so far as our studies go, we value most the accurate estimate of the influence of Chaitanya on that literature—accompanied by the grand Bengali Anthology Banga Sahitya Parichaya, 1914, and then above all the pleasing and erudite researches on Vaishnab literature and the connected religious reform of Chaitanya.

A world wholly legendary depicted with the homely tenderness in most secluded locality of Bengal and half conceived in the Buddhistic epoch with delicate phantasy and fondness; the

world in which Rabindranath Tagore ultimately attained his full growth is revived with every seduction of art in the luminous pages of this beautiful book. The author came in touch with this in his first days of youth when he was a village teacher in East Bengal and he now wishes to reveal it by gathering together the most secluded spirit and also the legend collected in four delicious volumes of D. R. Mazumdar, yet to be translated.

A spirit of renunciation in the devotion of wives in the love of tender and sorrowful ladies, in eagerness for patient sacrifice carry us back, as we have said, to the Buddhistic epoch of Bengal; it rises as an ideal of life and is transmitted to future generations traversed by the Mussalmani faith which also is pervaded by so many Buddhistic elements. Malancha, the sublime female incarnation of such an ideal—whose legend is translated in the last pages of this volume—the Lady wholly spiritual, a soul heroic in its devoted renunciation, mistress of her body who reveals in herself qualities that essentially belong to Idea, a creature of the soul, shaped by the aspiration to come into contact with the external world. Malancha loses her eyes and her hands, but so strong is her desire to see her husband that her eyes grow again and such is her desire to serve him that her hands also grow again.

In the popular narration the prose often assumes a poetic movement and metrical form. The archaic language that reminds us of remote antiquity is converted into lyric charm and becomes knotty in the prose, making us think pensively of the Vedic hymnology that entered the epic of Mahavarat.'' (Translated from the original Italian).

Extract from the Times Literary Supplement, April, 1921.

THE BENGALI RAMAYANAS

By Prof. Dineschandra Sen, Rai Bahadur, b.a., D.Litt.

(Published by the University of Calcutta. Rs. 4 As. 2).

The Indian epics deserve closer study than they have hitherto received at the hands of the average Englishman of culture. Apart from the interest of the main themes, the wealth of imagery and the beauty of many of the episodes, they are storehouses of information upon the ancient life of India and a key to the origin of customs which still live. Moreover, they show many curious affinities to Greek literature, which suggest the existence of legends common to both countries. The Ring of Polycrates is reproduced in other conditions in the "Sakuntalá," the *Alcestis* has its counterpart in the story of Sávitri, and the chief of the Pandavas descends into hell in the manner of Odysseus, though on a nobler errand.

The main theme of these lectures is the transformation of the old majestic Sanskrit epic as it came from the hands of Valmiki to the more familiar and homely style of the modern Bengali versions. The Rámáyana, we are told, is a protest against Buddhist monasticism, the glorification of the domestic virtues, proclaiming that there is no need to look for salvation outside the home. The Bengali version, while reducing the grandeur of the heroic characters to the level of ordinary mortals, bring the epic within the reach of the humblest peasant; they have their own virtues, just as the simple narrative of the Gospels has its own charm, though it be different in kind from that of Isaiah's majestic cadences. Thus in the Sanskrit poem "Kauçalya", Rama's mother, is sacrificing to Fire when she

hears of her son's exile; she does not flinch, but continues the sacrifice in the spirit of Greek tragedy, merely altering the character of her prayer. In the Bengali version she becomes an ordinary Bengali woman, giving vent to lamentations such as one hears every day in modern India. In the Nibelungenlied one sees the same kind of transformation from the old Norse sagas to the atmosphere of medieval chivalry.

The author approaches his subject in that spirit of reverence which is the due of all the great literature, and to him Válmiki's Rámáyana is the greatest literature in the world. The fact does not blunt his critical faculty; rather does it sharpen it, for, as he says in the preface, "historical research and the truths to which it leads do not interfere with faith," neither do they stand in the way of admiration. He sees more in the Rámáyana than the mere collection of legends into a Sanskrit masterpiece from which various versions have been made from time to time. He shows us how, as the centuries proceeded, each successive version was influenced by the spirit of the age, how the story became adapted to the purposes of religious propaganda, how in the interests of the Vaishnava cult the hero Ráma became the divine avatár of Vishnu, even at the risk of absurd situations. He takes us through the age of the Sákti influence, of Rámánanda's philosophy and its revolt against Mahomedan iconoclasm, of the flippant immorality of the eighteenth century. "These Bengali Rámáyanas," he says, "have thus quite an encyclopædic character, comprising, along with the story of Ráma, current theologies, folk-tales, and the poetry of rural Bengal of the age when they were composed." To him the Rámáyana is a yellow primrose, but it is something more; and if some of his theories seem over-fanciful, at least they have the merit of sincerity. To the student of folklore these lectures are to be recommended as an earnest and loving study of a fascinating subject.

From a Review in the "Folk-Lore."

"The Bengali Ramayana": Lectures delivered at the Calcutta University in 1916. By Rai Sahib Dineschandra Sen, B.A. Published by the University of Calcutta, 1920.

The Folk-Literature of Bengal: Lectures delivered at the Calcutta University in 1917. By the same Author. Published by the University of Calcutta, 1920.

It is a matter of congratulation that the author of these two volumes of lectures an eminent Bengali scholar and author of an important work, *The History of Bengali Language and Literature*, has devoted his attention to the folklore of his country, and that a lectureship on this subject has been founded in the University of Calcutta. In the first series of lectures he considers the questions connected with the Bengali versions of the great Indian epic, the "Ramayana" the work of Valmiki. The first result of his analysis of the poem is that, as might have been anticipated, the poet used much of the current folk-tradition. Many incidents in the epic closely resemble tales in the Buddhist Jatakas. The second theory suggested is that originally the cycle of legends connected with the demi-god Rama and the demon Ravana were distinct, and that it was left for the poet to combine them into one consistent narrative.

The second course of lectures deals with a series of folk-tales current among Musalmans in Bengal, which evidently embody early Hindu tradition. The influence of woman in preserving these tales, and particularly the scraps of poetry embodied in them, is illustrated in an interesting way, and he makes an important suggestion that tales of the Middle Kingdom, or the Upper Ganges Valley, were conveyed by the crews of ships sailing from the cost of Bengal to Persia and thus were communicated to the people of the West long before any translations of collections like the Panchatantra or Hitopadesa were available.

The learned author of the lectures is doing admirable work in a field hitherto unexplored, and the University of Calcutta deserves hearty commendation in its efforts to encourage the study of Indian folklore.

Times Literary Supplement, May 13, 1923.

THE FOLK-LORE OF BENGAL.

THE FOLK-LITERATURE OF BENGAL : BY RAI SAHIB DINESH-CHANDRA SEN. (Calcutta University Press.)

Those who are acquainted (we hope they are many) with Mr. Sen's other works, the outcome of Lectures delivered to Calcutta undergraduates in the author's function, as Ramtanu Lahiri Research Fellow in history of Bengali Language and Literature, will know exactly what to expect of his present delightful excursion into Bengali Folk-lore. There is some honour, to begin with, in the odd fact that he should be lecturing to Bengali lads on Bengali nursery tales in English. Mr. Sen is not, and does not profess to be, one of those remarkable Bengalis who like Sir Rabindranath Tagore, for example, are perfectly billingual to the extent of being able to think with equal ease, and write with equal felicity and justness of expression, in both languages. Let not this be regarded as a sin in the Ramtanu Lahiri Fellow. He thinks in Bengali, he thinks Bengali thoughts, he remains a pious Hindu, though his Hindu ideas are touched and stirred by contact with many kindly and admiring English friends. He is the better fitted to explain Bengal to the outer world. For he loves his native province with all his heart. He has no doubts as to the venerable origins, the sound philosophy, the artistic power, the suggestive beauty, all the many charms of the Bengali Saraswati, the sweet and smiling goddess, muse and deity alike, the inspirer and patron of a long

line of men of literature and learning too little known to the self-satisfied and incurious West.

A Hindu he remains, thinking Hindu thoughts, retaining proud and happy memories of his childhood and of the kind old men and women who fed his childish imagination with old world rhymes, with the quaintly primitive Bengali versions of the stately epics of Sanskrit Scriptures, with tales even more primitive, handed down by word of mouth by pious mothers, relics, perhaps, of a culture which preceded the advent of Hinduism in Bengal. What makes Mr. Sen's books so delightful to us in Europe is precisely this indefinable Hindu quality, specifically Bengali rather than Indian, something that fits itself with exquisite aptness to what he knows of the scenery and climate of the Gangetic delta where Mr. Sen was born, and where he has spent the whole time of his busy life as a student of his native literature. He began life as a village school master in Eastern Bengal, a land of wide shining meres and huge slow moving rivers, where the boatman sings ancient legends as he lazily plies the oar, and the cowherd lads on the low grassy banks of Meghna or Dhaleswari chant plaintive rhymes that Warren Hastings may have heard as he " proceeded up country " in his spacious " budgerow."

All these pleasant old rhymes and tale Mr. Sen loves with a more than patriotic emotion and admiration, and this sentiment he contrives to impart to his readers, even through the difficult and laborious medium of a foreign language. We can imagine his lectures to be pleasant by conversional than eloquent in the academical fashion. He tells the lads before him what life-long pleasure he has taken in the hereditary legends he shares with them. But in the present volumes, for example, he is driven to assume from time to time the austerity of a professional student of a comparative folk-lore, and so strays (unwittingly, we may be sure) into the region of heated controversy. Mr. Gourlay, distinguished administrator and student of the history of Bengal, has given Mr. Sen a friendly foreword. It is evident that this professional element in Mr. Sen's work has a little frightened his kind-

ly sponsor. "When I read the author's enthusiastic appreciation," he says, "of Bengali folk-tales, the thought crossed my mind that perhaps the Rai Sahib's patriotism had affected his judgment ; but after I had read the translation of the beautiful story of Malanchamala, I went back to the first lecture, and I knew that what he said was true."

Mr. Gourlay has expressed a hope that Mr. Sen will make a collection of Bengali folk-tales. It must be admitted that the late Rev. Lalbehari Dey's tales may well be supplemented. But surely Mr. Gourlay knows Daksina Ranjan Mazumdar's four wonderful and wholly delightful volumes, one of them with a preface of appreciation by Sir Rabindranath Tagore himself. Mr. Mazumdar may well claim to be the Grimm of Bengal, and Mr. Sen has repeatedly acknowledged his debt to his unwearied diligence in collecting Bengali folk tales. The wonder is that no one has yet translated the marvels of "Thakurdadar Jhuli," "Thakurmar Jhuli," "Thandidir Thale" and "Dadamahasayer Thali." Appropriately illustrated, sympathetically rendered, they may yet be the delight of Western nurseries, and form the best, the most natural and easy of introduction to Indian thought and literature. There are other admirable works for the nursery in Bengali, such as Miss Sita Devi's "Niret Gurur Kahini" and the volume of Hindustani Fairy tales translated by her and her sister. But there is only one Mazumdar, and we heartily hope that Mr. Sen's version of his Malanchamala in this volume will draw the attention of European students of Indian folk-lore to the four excellent collections we have mentioned. Their style, subtle, archaic yet colloquial, may well puzzle the translator, for not every one of us has the pen of a Charles Perrault. But the task is well worth attempting. Meanwhile Mr. Sen does well to remind us that two of the best of La Fontaine's Fables are taken from the "Panchatantra."

Bengali Ramayanas by D. C. Sen. From a review in the *Journal of Royal Asiatic Society* by Sir GEORGE GRIERSON—

"This is the most valuable contribution to the literature on the Rāma-saga which has appeared since Professor Jacobi's work on the Rāmāyaṇa was published in 1893. The latter was confined to Vālmīki's famous epic, and the present volume, from the pen of the veteran author of the *History of Bengali Language and Literature*, carries the inquiry on to a further stage, and throws light both on the origins of the story and on its later developments.

The subject covers so wide a ground, and its treatment exhibits so wide a field of Indian learning that, within the limited space available, it is impossible to do more than indicate the mere salient points adduced by the author, and, perhaps, to add a few new items of information.

It has long been admitted that the core of the Sanskrit Rāmāyaṇa—the portion written by Vālmīki himself—consists (with a few interpolations) of the second to the sixth books. The first and the seventh, in which Rāma is elevated from the stage of a heroic mortal to divinity, are later additions. The Rai Saheb, accepting these conditions, has been able to dispel part of the darkness which has hitherto enveloved the sources of Vālmīki's poem, and to trace its origin to three distinct stories, which the great poet combined into a single epic.

The oldest version is that contained in the Dasaratha Jātaka, in which Sïtā is said to be Rāma's sister. Rāma is banished to the Himâlaya, being accompanied by her and Laksmaṇa—under much the same story of palace intrigue as that told by Vālmīki,—and returns to reign after twelve years. He then marries his sister Sītā, and they live happily ever afterwards. She is not abducted by any one, and there is no mention either of Hanumān or Rāvaṇa.[1]

The second strand of the epic belongs to Southern India, where there grew up a cycle of legends[2] about a grand and noble

1 This was long ago recognized by A. Weber. See *Indian Antiquary*, Vol. i. p. 121.

2 We find much of this in that portion of the Uttara Kāṇda which Jacobi calls the Ravanois.

Brahmana.[1] Most of these stories are said to be collected in the Jain Rāmāyaṇa of Hemachandra, a work which I have not seen, and which is described by our author as far more a history of Rāvaṇa than of Rāma. On the other hand, a Buddhist work—the Lṇkâvatāra Sūtra—narrates a long discourse which Rāvaṇa held with the Buddha, and claims him as a follower of Mahāyāna Buddhism! He was thus revered by Hindus, Jainas and Buddhists alike.

The third strand was the floating group of legends related to ape-worship once widely current in India. In these Hanumān was at first connected with Śaivism, and there are still extant stories telling how Śiva made him over to Laksmaṇa for service under Rāma. Even at the present day it is not only the devotees of Visṇu who adore him, and Śaivas, but the crypto-Buddhists of Orissa claim him as a powerful divinity.

From materials taken from each of these three sources Vālmīki welded together his immortal poem. He refused sanction to the ancient legend that the Sītā whom Rāma married was his sister, but gave no hint as to her parentage. This was supplied in later works, such as the Adbhuta Rāmāyaṇa—a wonderful collection of old and fantastic traditions—in which she is described as the daughter of Mandôdarī, the wife of her abductor.[2]

After thus discussing the origins of the Rāma-saga, and its development by Vālmīki, the Rai Saheb proceeds to the main subject of his work—the Rāmāyaṇas of Bengal. None of them are translations of the Sanskrit epic. Like the celebrated *Rāmacaritamānasa* of Tulasī Dāsa, each author tells his story in his own way, weaving into it his own thoughts and ancient traditions

1 Numerous temples in Southern India are said to have been founded by Rāvana (see Bombay Gazetteer, I, i, 190 454, n. 1; XV, ii, 76, 290 ff., 341). He is said to have performed his celebrated austerities at Gokarṇa in Kanara (Bombay Presidency), a district which abounds in legends about him. Some of these have spread to very distant parts of India. For instance, the story of the loan to him of Śiva's "self-*liṇga*" (Gaz. XV, 290)

2 Vide J.R.A.S., 1921, p. 422. This story appears to have been widely spread. It reappears in the Kāshmīrī Rāmayaṇa popular in Kashmir. According to the Jaina *Uttara Purāṇa*, quoted by our author she was a daughter of Rāvaṇa himself.

current in his neighbourhood. They secured their general popularity by the thorough Bengalization of their theme. The scenery, the manners and customs, the religious rites, the very food, although placed in Lankā, are all those familiar to Bengal. The most famous, and one of the oldest, of these Rāmāyaṇas is that of Krttivāsa (fourteenth century). All these features are already found there, but later writers, falling under the influence of the Vaisṇava revival of Chaitanya, not only filled their poems with Vaisṇava doctrine and with theories about *bhakti*, but even transferred legends concerning Chaitanya to pseudo-prototypes in the war before Laṇkā.[1] Space will not permit me to mention all Krttivāsa's successors. Each had his own excellencies and his own defects. I therefore confine myself to calling attention to the incomplete Rāmāyaṇa of the Mymensingh poetess Candrāvatī. In one of her poems she tells her own beautiful and pathetic story, and there can be no doubt but that her private griefs, nobly borne, inspired the pathos with which her tale of Sītā's woes is distinguished. It is interesting that, like one or two other authors, she ascribes Sītā's banishment to Rāma's groundless jealousy. A treacherous sister-in-law, daughter of Kaikeyī, named Kukuā, persuaded Sītā, much against her will, to draw for her a portrait of Rāvaṇa. She then showed this to Rāma as a proof that his wife loved, and still longed for, her cruel abductor. This story was not invented by the poetess. It must have been

1 The Bengali version of the conversion of the hunter Vālmīki is worth noting for the light it throws on the connexion of Bengali with Māgadhī Prākrit. Nārada tried to teach him to pronounce Rāma's name, but he could not do so owing to sin having paraylsed his tongue. Nārada succeeded in getting him to say *madā* (pronounced *marā*, meaning "dead." This is the Māgadhī Prākrit *madā* (Vr. xi, 15). It is peculiar to the Bengali language, the more western word being *marā*. Nārada next got him to use this western pronunciation, and to repeat the word rapidly several times—thus, *marāmarāmarāmarä* It will be seen that in this way Vālmīki, without his paralysed tongue knowing it, uttered the word *Rāma*, and thus became sufficiently holy to become converted. *Apropos* of the *bhakti* influence, on page 127, there is a story about Nizāmu'd-din Auliā and a robber, which recalls the finale of the Tannhäuser. The robber is told that he cannot hope for forgiveness till a certain dead tree bears leaves. In process of time he does feel true repentance, and the dead trunk becomes at once covered with green leaves from top to bottom.

one of those long orally current, but not recorded by Vālmīki or by the writer of the seventh book of the Sanskrit poem, for it re-appears in the Kāshmīrī Rāmāyaṇa to which I have previously alluded.

A few words may also be devoted to another curious version of the old tradition. Under various orthodox names Buddhism has survived in Orissa to the present day, and, in the seventeenth century, one Rāmānanda openly declared himself to be an incarnation of the Buddha and, to prove it, composed a *Rāma-līlā* or Rāmāyana. I have already alluded to the fact that Hanumān was worshipped by this Orissa Buddhists. It need not therefore surprise us that Rāmānanda stated that he wrote his book under the ape-god's inspirátion.

I have drawn attention to only a few features of this excellent work in the hope that my remarks will induce those interested in the subject to buy the book and study it for themselves. It deserves attention, even if we do not accept all that its author wishes to prove. As a collection of hitherto unknown facts bearing on the development of the Rāma-saga in Bengal it is unique.

BENGALI PROSE STYLE
and
CHAITANYA AND HIS AGE

F. W. THOMAS—(Library, India Office, London) :

" I have now, however, given myself the pleasure of perusing the two volumes, which are worthy additions to your already great contributions to the study of your country's language, literature and history. The story which you tell of the development of Bengali as a language of modern prose has an interest which is much more than local. It shows how at different times different tendencies may be deliberately fostered and yet in the end the language may succeed in

deriving profit from them all and ultimately arrive at a style which exactly corresponds to its needs, and it also shows how important may be in such a development the influence of individual writers. The Sanskrit provided an admirable model of a classical speech, strong in logical structure and precision but by itself it was, no doubt, rather too cumbrous and inflexible for the variety and multifaraity of modern experience. I think that Bengali has been successful in its assimilation both of Sanskrit and of European influences. The points which you make concerning the non-verbal character of the rustic language and the old prose writings and concerning the varieties of grammatical forms admissible even in early writings of the nineteenth century are curious. Of course the nominal style became characteristic of Sanskrit also in its later developments and was no doubt due to ethnic factors. That the modern Bengali has returned to a full use of the verb and that it has made a choice among the varieties of inflextional forms, thereby fixing a literary norm, and that it took place in less than a century—these are facts highly creditable to the intellectuality and taste of the people, and of course, you have gone on to the finer developments and made your prose writing a real art, capable of reflecting not only the general level of thinking, but also the subtleties of the idiosyncracy of particular writers.

I have also found your 'Chaitanya' of great interest. Although I myself am by nature inclined to the *Jnana-marga* and little drawn to the Bhakti-cult for which reason I had hitherto regarded Chaitanya only from the outside—your book has enabled me to realize somewhat the intensity of his religious emotions, his goodness and the deep effect which these combined to produce. The fact that he commenced as a Pandit is highly important, since it shows that not undeveloped intellectuality but the overpowering impulses of his nature were what determined his mission.

M. Levi justly congratulates you on preserving your critical judgment, in the presence of so highly emotional an atmosphere, and inspite of the fact that your own feeling strongly responds thereto. I have taken note of some eloquent passages in which your personal sentiment is in fact distinctly helpful to the readers

by enabling him to realize the matter from the inside. And your book seems to me indispensable both for those who approach Chaitanya from the scholarly side and for those who wish to understand the mind and history of Bengal.''

CHAITANYA AND HIS AGE.

Elaborate notices of these works have appeared in many journals of Europe and India.

From a long review in *Journal Asiatique* for January to March 1923: ''Among books published entirely under one signature and not noticed up to now, it is necessary to mention first those of the indefatigable Dinesh Chandra Sen. Everywhere we find the proof of the profound knowledge which Mr. Sen possesses of a subject which he has renovated by his discoveries and of his enthusiasm for that mysticism which borrows the language of terrestrial love to express the diverse phases of the Divine love. In the last book (Chaitanya and his Age) which is the most agreeable to read and without doubt the most important, after having described the life of Chaitanya..... Mr. Sen has added a very interesting supplement on the various sects which according to him are only Vaishnavite in name..... the Sahajias, the Bauls, etc. These he believes to be the sects of disguised Mahajanism.....'' (''*Translated from French*'').

EMILE SENART, President, Asiatic Society, Paris :—I thank you for the two volumes that you have sent me. I was getting ready in accordance with your wish to bring them to the notice of the readers of the Asiatic Journal. But I was anticipated by M. Jules Bloch : you will see his article in the forthcoming issue of the journal. But at least I want to tell how greatly I appreciate the powerful art which for many years you have put at the service of Bengali Literature and how much I really felt the charm of the biography of Chaitanya. Your warm

enthusiasm for the mystic side of religion and the cult of Krishna expressed themselves in such a touching manner! You have not conceived it in a narrow way—in the manner of the West. So that for us it does not lose the interest and seems a continuation in the heart and in the imagination of the remarkable and emotional action of this man of religious contemplation.

Believe, dear co-worker, in the expression of my deep gratitude and devotion. (*Translated from French.*)

From a long review in the *Pioneer*—12th August, 1923.

"The author displays zeal, energy, and learning of no common order. He is filled with a passionate conviction of the truth of what he writes. Further, he is familiar with the apparatus criticus of modern scholarship ; gives full references and weighs his authorities with solemn impartiality.....Much care, learning and scholarship have been directed to the task of separating the historic from the legendary element in the many sources with which the author concerns himself. The result is a picture which, so far as the data from which it is constructed are concerned, leaves little to be desired....."

HIS EXCELLENCY LORD RONALDSHAY wrote a letter of appreciation. He pointed out some errors ; his letter is, however, quoted here with some omission. It will show the deep interest with which His Excellency reads all publications of the Calcutta University of which he was once the Chancellor.

"I need hardly say that I have read 'Chaitanya and his Age' with the utmost pleasure. It seems to me to give a vivid account of the time when there was a great flowering of the emotional temperament of Bengal, due in large measure, no doubt, to a reaction against the frigid intellectualism of the monistic school of Vedanta Philosophers—or as you call them—pantheists. We see the same thing, do we not, in the case of Ramakrishna Paramahamsa, of Dakhineswar, in that he laid stress upon the supreme value of the Bhakti-cult?

Your chapter on Sahajia is extremely interesting and recalled with great vividness the talk which we had at Barrackpur on that subject. But until I read your recent volume, I had not realised that there were so many sects of Sahajias or that the cult was so wide-spread. Nor, I think, had I realised how wide is the gulf between the mass of the people who have been untouched by western education and their western-educated fellow countrymen. Babu Parvaticharan Kabishekhar's ' Charu Darshan ' must be an interesting novel from this point of view, and I agree with you that it ought to be translated into English. Why not encourage some of your pupils to undertake this? In case you may be bringing out a further edition of ' Chaitanya and his Age ' at any time, I note down a few printer's errors that happened to catch my eye as I read it. (Here His Excellency refers to some mistakes.)

There are also some little discrepancies in connection with the date of Chaitanya's birth. Thus on page 102 you say that Jagannath Misra was 48 years old at the birth of Chaitanya and was himself born in 1435. This would make the date of Chaitanya's birth 1483. On page 103 you mention a copy of Mahabharata made in 1468 by Jagannath or 17 years before Chaitanya's birth. This would make the date of the latter 1485. Again on page 106 you say that Jagannath died of fever in 1506 when Chaitanya was only 20, which makes the date of Chaitanya's birth 1486. This latter date is the one which you tell us on page 109 is accepted by the Vaisnaba historians. These are all trifling matters and I only mention them in case it may be of use to you."

THE EASTERN BENGAL BALLADS

With a Foreword by the Right Hon'ble Lawrence John Lumley Dundas, Earl of Ronaldshay.

From a Review in the Oriental List, London (Jan.-March, 1924).

"*Eastern Bengal Ballads : Mymensingh*" : Ramtanu Lahiri Research Fellowship Lectures for 1922-24 in two parts.

In these two volumes Dr. Dineschandra Sen has for the first time made available, both for English and for Bengali readers, ten typical ballads (gathas) sung by professional minstrels in the district of Mymensingh. The words of the ballads have been taken down in writing from the lips of those who sing them by one Chandrakumar De, who has travelled into many out-of-the-way places in East Bengal for this purpose. It was an extremely difficult task to which he set himself ; he often found the professional singers whom he approached unwilling to disclose to a stranger the text of these songs, which had been handed to them as a private family possession; to recover the whole of a ballad he often had to make special journeys to several different places and to consult a number of different singers; and throughout his work he was handicapped by ill-health. It is to be hoped that the collaboration between him and Dr. Sen will continue and result in the preservation of many more of these ballads, which are of immense value both to the student of folk-lore and to the philologist.

The ballads mostly date from the 16th and 17th centuries, and throw a flood of light on the social, religious and political condition of Eastern Bengal in those days. The first volume (Vol. I, Part I) contains a valuable introduction by Dr. Sen, and an English translation (or more strictly a paraphrase) of the ten ballads. There is also a separate introduction to each ballad. The second volume (Vol. I, Part II) contains a Bengali introduction, the full Bengali text of each ballad, and a number of footnotes

explaining obsolete words and provincialisms. There are eleven illustrations, and a literary map of Eastern Mymensingh. Embodied in some of the ballads are several interesting specimens of ' baramasi ' poems—poems describing the twelve months of the year in relation to the experiences of the hero and heroine of the poem. The language throughout is the common village speech of the Mymensingh district, and is in delightful contrast to the artificial style of such writers as Bharatchandra, with its far-fetched conceits and high-sounding Sanskrit expressions.

Great as Dr. Sen's other services to the cause of Bengali literature have been, it is doubtful whether any of his previous work is a more valuable contribution to our knowledge of Bengali life and thought than this collection of ballads, which, but for his enterprise and the praiseworthy efforts of his collaborator, would in all probability in the course of the next few years, have been lost beyond recovery."

From a review in the Times Literary Supplement of 7th August, 1924.

" A writer needs more than merit in himself if his work is to attract wide notice; his subject-matter must have a quality of general appeal. Probably no scholar alive in India to-day has such a record as Dr. Dineschandra Sen, a record of patient, enthusiastic pioneer research, whose results have been valuable and full of interest. Fifty years ago, very little was known, even by Bengalis, of old Bengali literature, and if such ignorance no longer prevails to-day, it is largely because of one man who, in spite of poverty and obscure beginnings and ill-health, has toiled through many years to bring his own land's history and literature to light. His journeyings should become a legend, and the Bengali imagination, centuries hence, should see one figure eternally traversing the Gangetic plain, now beaten upon by the fierce sun as he makes his way across the red, deeply fissured fields of Vishnupur, now floating on the rain-swept rivers of East Bengal. He has

coaxed a cautious peasantry into opening their store of traditions and memories, and he has persuaded them to part with hundreds of old manuscripts that were stuffed into palm-leaf roofs or between bamboo rafters. If he has not made a nation's ballads he has discovered a great many of them. If a small part of this service had been rendered to a better-known literature it would have made him famous. But Bengal is popularly supposed to have had no history; and it has certainly been without the dramatic or catastrophic events which strike the imagination in the story of many lands. Plassey, despite Nabin Sen's song of lament over it, was not a disaster to Bengali arms though fought in Bengal. Agra and Lahore, Delhi and Seringapatam, evoke more romantic associations than Dacca or Murshidabad. Aurangzeb and Akbar, Pratap Singh and Tipu Sultan, mean a good deal even to a European; but Lakshman Sen and Hambir Singh mean nothing at all.

Yet the records brought to light by Dr. Sen concern a population of fifty millions, who speak as expressive and beautiful a language as there is anywhere in India, and whose literature is a thing that Indians outside Bengal regard with pride, as an enrichment of their common heritage. That literature has been flowering with amazing exuberance for nearly a century now; and as the Bengali mind grows in consciousness of itself and its achievement, it must increasingly be interested in the beginnings of that achievement. In his latest book, Dr. Sen has reclaimed a whole province for scholarship and study, the ballads of the Mymensingh borderland. As we know, a debatable land, where races and interests meet and sometimes clash, has a vivid life which often takes on spontaneous and vigorous expression. And the Mymensingh swamps and spreading rivers, a refuge to fugutive kings and struggling independences, a region where Bengal and Assam, Aryan and Mongolian meet and merge, have sheltered through the centuries much more than moving and beautiful stories. A great deal of Bengal's forgotten and neglected history lies hidden in these ballads.

In his introduction Dr. Sen tells how his notice was first drawn to the ballads. Nearly a dozen years ago he was interested

by articles in an obscure and local Magazine, and on inquiry found that they were by one Chandra Kumar De, a young man of no English education, in frail health and wretchedly poor. He had been employed by a village grocer, on a salary of one rupee (sixteen pence) a month, "but was dismissed on the plea of incompetence and inattention." Probably the employer had reason for his action, for the boy was dreaming of his own country and her past. He got new work, this time munificently paid by two rupees a month, the work of a rent-collector; he had to travel widely, and during his travels heard the old ballads. Dr. Sen persuaded Calcutta University to employ him; and by an expenditure of fifty rupees a month for three years over 17,000 lines of Old Bengali poetry have been recovered. Dr. Sen exultantly remarks :

"I would not have been more pleased if these lines were all gold. The songs perfectly artless, written mostly by Hindu and Muhammadan peasants, often show the real heart of poetry, and some of them at least, I believe, will rank next only to the most beautiful of the Viasnava songs in our literature."

He has found European scholars who share his enthusiasm. If other friends, both in England and Bengal, renew the charge that his enthusiasm for what is old is often like the uncritical joy of a man madly in love, he is unmoved. The charge is familiar to him, and he puts it by with a smile. The mass of work that he has now brought forward is too large for hasty assessment, and even on a first view much of it is manifestly poorer than he thinks it. But among these ballads are some tales so simple and appealing that they need only a more cunning literary presentation to win recognition outside Bengal. And Dr. Sen, throughout his long and successful career as discoverer, has never done his land greater service than by saving these stories that would so soon have faded out from the world."

Paris, 10th April, 1924.

My dear Friend,

I am sorry I could not answer earlier your lovely letter, dated 10th January, 1924. I am growing more and more busy day by

day since my coming back home. Still I cherished the hope of reading all your Ballads before writing you, and I kept them faithfully on my desk all the time. But I had to content myself with the first one and with your learned Introduction. To-day I am on the eve of Easter vacations, and I am confident I can now make time to enjoy a full reading of your delectable work. But I have read enough of it to anticipate the pleasure I can derive from it. Your enthusiasm at the discovery was fully justified. Your Eastern Bengal, you are so proud of, is positively an earthly replica of India's *Nandan*, a paradise of vegetation, sky, running water, a sporting place of Apsarases and Gandharvas, and you are another Narada coming to the world to repose above these celestial beauties, and in a way how attractive! This is the wonder of art that, owing to you, I could in the sad, dull, dim days of winter dream of a blue sky, of lovely rivers, of evergreen woods, of couples of lovers wandering amidst the wild beasts, indifferent to all dangers, raptured by their mutual love.

There is one dark side, the news you give me about your bad health. It may be that after such an unceasing strain of labour you had to suffer from a nervous depression. Even before I could meet you, I could guess that you are working in a constant strain of imagination and passion which overtaxes your bodily strength. I know that no sacrifice is of account to you for the love of your country. But India has not such a plenty of worthy worshippers that the loss of one of them may be indifferent. The work that you can do no one else can do or will do. Think of it and keep yourself ready for more work. This is a friend's wish and prayer.

But do not miss to send me a word that you are feeling better, and stronger, that you are recovering after this tremendous shock.

Believe me, my dear friend,
Ever yours,
Sylvain Levi.

Dear Sir,

Thank you very much for your kindness in sending me the first volume of your Mymensingh Ballads. My sister and myself

(she is my interpreter in English) have read it with great interest. The subject it deals with touches all mankind; the differences with European stories are due to reasons which are much more social than racial. The good æsthetic taste that is felt in most of these ballads is also one of the characteristics of popular imagination in many of our Western countries : " Womeder Wehmuth " as a beautiful song of Goethe's, put into music by Beethoven, expresses it " The Pleasure of Tears."

It is true that with us French people, the people of Gaul, it reacts against this with our bold and boisterous joyful legends. Is there none of this kind of thing in Indian literature? I was specially delighted with the touching story of Madina which although only two centuries old, is an antique beauty and a purity of sentiment which art has rendered faithfully without changing it. Chandravati is a very noble story and Mahua, Kanka and Lila are charming (to mention only these ones).

The patient researches of Mr. Chandra Kumar De and your precious collaboration with him have brought to the historical science a valuable contribution to its efforts to solve the problems of popular literary creations. From where have these great primitive epics and ballads come? It seems very likely that they have always come from some poetic genius whose invention has struck the popular imagination. But the question is how much people deform his idea in putting it into the shape in which we find it? Which is the part of the collaboration of the multitude in this work of re-casting, which is continuous and spontaneous? Rarely has any one had the happy opportunity to seize an epic as one might say on the lips of the people who have given birth to it before writing had fixed it in some shape as you and Mr. Chandra Kumar have succeeded in doing in this case. I congratulate you sincerely for this beautiful work and I ask you, dear Sir, to believe in my high esteem and admiration.*

4th March, 1924. ROMAIN ROLLAND.

* Translated from French by Captain J. W. Petavel.

From a review by Mr. E. F. OATEN, LL.B., M.A.,
published in the *Englishman*, dated the
7th of February, 1924.

It is not easy for an Englishman to hazard an opinion as to the reception which the ballad poetry of Eastern Bengal, recently rescued from oblivion by Dr. Sen, and now given by him to the world in the form of an English translation, will receive at the hands of literary Bengal. But one thing is certain. The measure of Bengal's appreciation of these ballads, not as mere historical or literary curiosities, but as living literature, will be some index of the extent to which her spirit is escaping from the trammels of artificiality in its effort to express itself not only in literature but in life. To the western critic, stumbling by good fortune upon Dr. Sen's Book, these ballads, straight from the unsophisticated people's heart, come fresh and stimulant as the breeze that revives the jaded traveller from Calcutta as he sits in steamer and ploughs across the monsoon gusts of Eastern Bengal. In them we escape, as regards the subject-matter almost entirely from the priest, as regards language, entirely from cultured artificiality, and as regards the most universal of human passions, altogether from that ideal of chastity which caused a poet of an earlier age to place the following words in the mouth of Sita, as a defence to her character : "Even when I was a mere child, I never came too close to a male play-fellow."

In the introduction which Dr. Sen prefixes to his translation, we learn that these ballads cover a period of 300 years from the sixteenth century onward, that they were known only and that orally only, solely to the class, rapidly decreasing, of professional village-singers or rhapsodists; and that he collected the ballads through the agency of a poverty-stricken and uneducated literary enthusiast, named Chandra Kumar De, to whom the real credit for first bringing these ballads to literary notice must be ascribed, though Dr. Sen's work in introducing them to a wider literary world, and inspiring the discovery of others, has been infinitely valuable.

Briefly stated, these ballads contain a picture of the state of society and the conditions of life, prevailing in Eastern Mymensingh in the 16th century and onward. The area in which the ballads rose and flourished was one into which the Sen Rajas with the Brahminic canons and arbitrary conventions were unable to penetrate; it was therefore for generations ruled by a different society and a different standard of moral and communal life; its culture was indigenous, natural, fresh, unartificial, in short, true original Bengali. It was a society not of dogmas, but of real life.

There are a dozen aspects from which these ballads, thus redeemed from rapidly approaching oblivion, are important. Lord Ronaldshay in his introduction emphasises their importance as the seed from which modern Bengali has sprung. They will certainly also prove valuable as a source of historical information. But one cannot but dwell here on their intrinsic value as literature, since it is to be hoped that Bengal will eventually value them most as such. As Dr. Sen writes, " these songs have features in them which have a universal appeal." Their language is that of a despised " patois," they describe Bengali men and women acting in ways that are not now conventional and are in some cases regarded as immoral; but they describe the great human passions, and chiefly the passions of love, working in social conditions that were, as compared with conditions to-day, strangely unrestricted by conventions. In these ballads women fall in love, and in no case blindly follow the selection of the guardian. They go through fire and water for the sake of the man they choose. They devise stratagems and slay his foes. They converse with strange youngmen at the ghat and arrange future meetings. They receive love-letters. Yet ever they prefer death to dishonour, properly so regarded. Malua's scorn of the Kazi's overtures to her through a go-between, in her husband's absence, is characteristic. " The wicked Kazi has not the worth of my husband's toe. Take this insult from me and go to your Kazi and tell him all. I take him to be my foe and hold him as a dog. I hit his face with a broom from here."

In fact it may be said that woman, the Bengali woman, is the general hero of these ballads, so far as those hitherto published are concerned. By the side of her devotion, heroism and self-renunciation, the male characters are sometimes poor creatures, devoid of personality. In Mahua, Malua, Sunai and several others, not solely Hindu, the literature of Bengal receives on its roll many names of which it may be proud. It is therefore distressing to learn from Dr. Sen that these songs are losing public favour every day. Bengal needs these literary heroines, even though, or even possibly because their conventions are not those of to-day. Possibly Dr. Sen's book, and especially his enthusiastic and triumphant introduction to them, will restore them to public favour, and give them wider currency. It is clear at least from Dr. Sen's enthusiasm for the unconvetionality of the characters of the ballads, that it is not without meaning that he prefaces to his book the quotation that " if a man were permitted to make all the ballads, he need not care who should make the laws of a nation."

Lord Ronaldshay in an article entitled " What is it Nationalist India wants " published in " the Nineteenth Century and After " (July 1924) refers to Dr. Dineschandra Sen's " Eastern Bengal Ballads " in terms of high praise, with copious extracts from the book.

From a review by Mr. F. E. PARGITER, (I.C.S. retired) in the *Royal Asiatic Society's Journal* (October, 1924) :

Songs and ballads have been handed down orally and recited among the peasantry in the district of Mymensingh in North-East Bengal, and Chandra Kumar De, a poor man who had been fascinated by them during his local visits as rent-collector, began writing about them in the local Journal *Sourabha* in 1912. His notices attracted Dr. Dineschandra Sen, who then helped him and engaged him in 1919 to recover all the ballads that could be discovered there. This was done, often with great difficulty, because reciters did not always know the whole of a ballad, so that the portions were discovered piecemeal and sometimes con-

fusedly. Dr. Sen has now edited ten ballads as a first instalment in this work, the ballads (Maimansingha Gītikā) in Pt. II and English translations in Pt. I.

The Bengali of the ballads is the peculiar dialect of East Bengal, which differs from that of Calcutta in various respects, and is of real interest and value in phonology and vocabulary, as the reviewer can vouch from personal knowledge, some results of which are shown in his *Vocabulary of Peculiar Vernacular Bengali* Works, published by the Bengal Asiatic Society. The English version is not a close translation, but a free rendering which gives the matter and spirit of the original. The ballads belong to the last three or four centuries. The dramatis personæ are Hindu and Mohammedan, chiefly Hindu yet not Hindu of the orthodox type, for the conditions are those of freer country life, and youth and maiden meet in true love episodes. The stories are charming, both happy and tragic, and are told generally in simple language, fresh with country scenes and feelings, and illustrated with pretty sketches by a Bengali artist. The characters are finely and often nobly delineated, and the heroines display the highest ideals of Bengali womanhood. Dr. Sen has discussed each ballad in a preface, and has prefixed to the whole a long introduction investigating their origin, variety, nature, recitation and value, and the political condition of that district. The ballads should stimulate interest among students of Bengali, and the English version will charm all readers.

Luzac's Oriantal List, London, Jan.-March, 1926.

Glimpses of Bengal Life. By Rai Bahadur Dinesh Chandra Sen, B.A., D.Litt. (Hon.), etc. In this volume, which consists almost entirely of lectures delivered to the Calcutta University in 1915 (and subsequently revised), Dr. Sen rambles discursively over a large range of topics connected with the old literature and life of Bengal, and, as might be expected from a scholar of his distinction, *nihil tangit quod non ornat.* The early part of the book is concerned with the high standard of rectitude and lofty sex morality which is revealed in the rustic ballads. The author passes on to discuss the system of espionage adopted by the ancient rulers ; costume ; the influence of Islam on the Hindu Courts; and the superior observation of nature of the old writers, as compared with modern Bengali poets. Then follow some stray notes on the curious Mainâmati songs and the story of Gorakshanath, and an examination of certain features of the life and teaching of the Vaishnava poet Chandîdâs. The next section deals with the story of Chaitanya's desertion of Nadia, as revealed in the usually neglected sayings of the Vaishnava poets. To many readers the most interesting part of the book will be the chapter devoted to humour in Old Bengali literature; and the description of Bharat Chandra's character of the sage Vyâsa, which is in the best style of comedy, may be recommended to all who are inclined to disparage Indian humour. The supplement is an excellent specimen of literary controversy, in which Dr. Sen convincingly champions the authenticity of the Karcha of Govinda Dâs.